

Rel 201 God, The Bible & Humanity

Numbered Transcript

REL 201 • Bishop Robert Barron

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Lecture 1: God Beyond Being

At a glance — Barron on God beyond being.

- 1.1 Well, good to be with everybody today. Thanks for coming. My topic today, and the following days, is going to be my favorite topic of all, which is God, and more precisely, God and our relation to God, because I really think no matter what your perspective, there are no questions more important than that. What is ultimate reality, and what's my relationship to that reality?
- 1.2 The biblical point of view, and I'm going to be drawing almost exclusively from the Bible in these talks—the biblical perspective is I find joy and purpose in the measure that I'm rightly related to the true God, and concomitantly, my life gets off-kilter. My life goes haywire in the measure that I'm out of right relationship to the true God. In a way, those are the most fundamental issues, period. As I say now, I'll be working pretty much exclusively from the Bible.
- 1.3 So, I want to say just a couple of things before we get into the formal lectures about the Bible because I find people are blocked when it comes to the Bible, a lot of folks, and it comes from forms of fundamentalism that get in the way of approaching the Bible. I want to say three simple things as we start.
- 1.4 The first difficulty is people think there's one hermeneutical lens through which we should read the entire Bible. One interpretive key. "Do you read the Bible literally?" people ask, which, to my mind, is about as misguided as saying, "Do you read the library literally?" because the Bible, even though it's between these two covers and length thematically and all those good things, nevertheless, is a collection of texts, not simply a text.
- 1.5 So, in the Bible, you have poetry, you've got quasi mythological literature, you've got historical literature, but even there, not history in our sense, but ancient history. You've got biographies, the gospels, but they're ancient biographies, not like the ones we write today. You've got epistolary literature, letters from Paul, you have apocalyptic. All of these genres are to be read in different ways.
- 1.6 So, there isn't one clunky set of glasses we wear to read the whole Bible, but we have to be attentive to the genre. Keep in mind, too, written at different times by different authors to different audiences for different purposes. And all that's got to be taken into consideration when we read the Bible.
- 1.7 Here's a second problem, and I'm going to put it in terms of William Placar, who died just a few years ago. He was a great protestant theologian. He said, "Not everything that's in the Bible is what the Bible teaches." It's a very important distinction. And I would say, as a Catholic, that's very close to my own heart. "Not everything that's in the Bible is what the Bible teaches."

- 1.8** So, someone opens up the Bible, "Look, there it is. The Bible says—" but the right approach is not that. It's rather to look at the great themes, patterns, and trajectories within the Bible. That's closer to what the Bible is actually teaching. Some might say, "Look, slavery is mentioned here in the Bible." Well, yeah, I would say that was along for the ride culturally at the time. Is it what the Bible is teaching? If we look at the deep patterns and themes and the overall trajectory of the Bible, I would say clearly no. One evidence for that is the leading advocates of abolition go back to the 18th and 19th century. We're biblically formed people, attentive, I'd say, not just to what's in the Bible but to what the Bible is teaching.
- 1.9** So, that leads to my third consideration. Would you ever say to a kid, "Just pick up Hamlet and start reading it, and you'll be fine. You'll understand Hamlet or Macbeth; pick it up and read it." No, of course not. You want to put those into a grand interpretive tradition. You want to read the great commentators on these plays. You want to talk to actors who've been in these plays. It's within a tradition that we understand Shakespeare. The same thing with the Bible. Again, it's a rather catholic instinct of mine. I wouldn't just hand this book or collection of books to someone and say, "Just read it. You'll be fine." No, no. You have to read it within the interpretive tradition, which I would call the church.
- 1.10** So, these principles will be informing everything I'll be saying now in the next several lectures. I'll be reading the Bible from that perspective. What I'm going to be doing is looking at, if we have time, 13 sections—an unlucky number, but that's the way it worked out. Thirteen sections from the Bible, both Old Testament and New, that I think speak to this fundamental issue: who is God? What is ultimate reality? And then, what's our right relationship to that reality? Okay?
- 1.11** So, let's begin with Exodus 3:14, one of the most famous texts in the scriptures—by the way, the scriptures. That gives it away, doesn't it? We don't say the scripture; we say the scriptures. The word Bible, from the Greek *ta biblia*, is a plural, 'the books.' So, that's the point.
- 1.12** So, look at Exodus 3:14. We know that the Bible—maybe Proverbs, the book of wisdom, might be exceptional—but the Bible typically does not use philosophical language. Rather, it speaks in the language of metaphor and symbol and, above all, narrative. It's within this more literary form that the truths of the Bible are communicated. So, we could simply take the passage Exodus 3:14, God's self-definition, and begin to philosophize about it. Much better to look at it a bit narratively. Then, we'll come to its deeper meaning.
- 1.13** So, we're dealing here with Moses, his experience of the burning bush, and hearing God's name. But what's the narrative setting? Well, we know that during a time of persecution, Pharaoh is putting to death the male babies of the Hebrews. Moses' mother saves him, putting him in the little basket, floats down the Nile. He's found by the daughter of Pharaoh.

- 1.14** So, without going into the whole Cecil B. DeMille picture, we can say Moses was raised as a prince of Egypt. He was raised as an aristocratic figure, probably used to getting his way, probably pretty imperious. What's the first thing we really hear about him? He sees an Egyptian mistreating a Hebrew. He kills the man, buries him, and then, when he finds out that it's been discovered, he hightails it out of the country.
- 1.15** Now, does that strike you as someone really in control of himself, someone who's really got it together morally and psychologically? No. It seems like a pretty imperious, self-absorbed, self-important person. Gets what he wants when he wants it. In other words, may I say, someone utterly unprepared for an experience of God.
- 1.16** Here's the basic thing, everybody. Yes, there's an intellectual dimension to all this. You can bring someone intellectually toward a clearer understanding of God. But a basic biblical sense is you also have to be ordered properly if you want to see God. If you're completely off the grid in terms of your psychology and your own spiritual attitude, you will not be able to see God. Time and time again in the Bible, before the great figures have an encounter with God, they have to go through a purification.
- 1.17** So, the image we get of Moses is someone that really needs it. And so, he self-exiles, which is a good thing, by the way. He goes into the desert, the desert where things are stripped away, the desert where I'm not in command. I remember years ago when I was doing pastoral work, and you'd bring kids from the city out into the country or out into the wilderness, and what struck them very often was, "I can't control my life here, the weather, that mountain, and these woods, they're out of my control." Good.
- 1.18** That's why holy people and spiritual seekers over the centuries often go into the wilderness, into the tundra, or, in the biblical setting, into the desert where things are stripped away. Life becomes simplified. You become disciplined. How long did it take? Long time because he marries, he starts a family, etcetera. We're not talking about a short sojourn here, like a little vacation in the desert. No, no. Years.
- 1.19** Think here, too, that marvelous story of Joseph. I don't have time to go into that one with all of its spiritual power, but young Joseph with the many-colored coat, and he's his father's favorite. And he says to his brothers, "I had a dream that you'd bow down to me." Of course, they hated him. Of course, they sold him into slavery, and his dream came true. We know from that marvelous story that the brothers do indeed bow to him one day because he becomes the vizier of Egypt. But imagine if that little kid, that rather obnoxious, self-absorbed 12-year-old kid, had become, at that moment, vizier of Egypt. Forget it. What he needed were years and years and years of discipline, including imprisonment. Well, that's a deep biblical intuition. We need to be readied for the vision of God.
- 1.20** That's the narrative setting now that sets us up for this third chapter of Exodus. "Moses was keeping the flock of his father-in-law, Jethro, the priest of Midian. He led his flock beyond the wilderness and came to Horeb, the mountain of God. There, the angel of

the Lord appeared to him in a flame of fire out of a bush. He looked, and the bush was blazing, yet it was not consumed." The whole spiritual life, in a way, is in that little description.

- 1.21 First of all, everybody, God has to be in control of a right relationship to God. Let me say that again. If our relationship to God is right, God has to be in control of it. If I say, "I'm going to figure God out on my terms and my way by asking my questions," right from the start, you're off track. God makes himself manifest to us. We speak of God revealing himself. Revelatio means 'taking the veil away.' God discloses himself to us.
- 1.22 That's why, how often in the spiritual tradition waiting and keeping vigil is mentioned? Waiting. Sometimes, all you can do is wait because you can't be in control of it. God has to make himself manifest. And so, he does, and in this remarkable sign, "the flame of fire burning and not consuming the bush." When the true God gets close to us and gets close to the world, we and the world become radiant and beautiful, and we are not consumed. It's a fundamental biblical intuition. The closer the true God gets to us, the more radiant and beautiful we become, and we are not consumed.
- 1.23 Can I set up a contrast here between this vision and what you find in the classical myths? In the Greek and Roman myths, when the gods enter into human affairs, what happens? People are incinerated; people are destroyed because the gods are basically competitive to this world. And the more they assert themselves, the more the world has to give way. Now, we sinners know about this because we're the same way. For me to be famous, or me to be in charge, or me to be powerful, you gotta give way. But look at now this image of God. God comes close, and the bush is on fire. Beautiful, compelling, and it's not consumed. It's more fully and marvelously itself the closer God gets.
- 1.24 Can I cite here one of my very favorite theologians, Irenaeus of Lyon, a very ancient figure, a church father. He said, "Gloria dei homo vivens." It means, "The glory of God is a human being fully alive." Right. That's the Bible. It's not that the glory of God's when God can knock us around or God can destroy us as he comes barreling into our experience. No, no. God's glory is that the world becomes radiant and beautiful with his presence. There's a first fundamental insight here.
- 1.25 So, listen now, as it goes on. Moses said, "I must turn aside and look at this great site and see why the bush is not burned up." He's been in the desert for a while, but he's still not completely in good shape. This is still somebody who wants to be in command of things. What's that? Let me go check it out. Let me find out what this thing is. It's this aggressively inquisitive attitude.
- 1.26 "When the Lord saw that he had turned aside to see, God called him out of the bush, 'Moses, Moses!' And he said, 'Here I am.'" Okay, this God seems pretty friendly. He knows my name and he's calling to me. But then, what?

- 1.27** "Come no closer. Remove the sandals from your feet, for the place in which you are standing is holy ground." Sandals. If you're wearing sandals or shoes, you can make your way pretty confidently, no matter where you are. You can walk over rocky ground, or you can walk—you're in command. Take off your shoes. Taking off of the shoes—a lot of ways we can read that, but one way is it's putting you properly now in a much more receptive, passive attitude. So, yes, come close. Yes, I know your name, but don't think you can control me.
- 1.28** Watch this, everybody, in the spiritual tradition—and I'm going to talk about it a little more philosophically later— there's always this play between come close and keep your distance, between intimacy with God but not controlling God. It's a play between invitation and distantiation. And that's typical in all the spiritual masters, too, but you see it here.
- 1.29** God says, "I am the God of your father, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, the God of Jacob." Well, "Who is this God who knows my name?"—Moses must be thinking —"And he knows my people. And who are my people right now, by the way? They're slaves in Egypt. They're not masters of the universe types. They're slaves. But this God knows my distant ancestors, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and he knows the suffering of my people. How intimate this God is to my experience?" He's observed the misery of his people—all of that.
- 1.30** So, Moses now is getting pretty confident again. "This God is pretty intimate with me, and he knows my name. So—what—I'm going to ask his name." Makes sense, right? If you have somebody's name, you've got control over that person to that degree. I can put you in my contacts. I can call out to you and make you respond. I can ask people about you if I know your name. Knowing someone's name is a controlling move. So, when Moses says to God, "If I come to the Israelites and say, 'The God of our ancestors sent me to you,' what will I tell them if they say, 'What's his name?'" And here's our exodus, 3:14. This is the text: "God said to Moses, 'I am who I am. You shall say to the Israelites, I am has sent me to you.'"
- 1.31** In one sense, I would hold to this. It is God's way of saying, "Stop asking stupid questions." Moses' question is born of his ordinary experience. To ask for someone's name is to ask, "What kind of being are you? Or which one are you among the many? There's all these human beings here. I can say, what's your name, and what's your name? I'm asking, what defines you?" In this time, there were all kinds of gods. Gods of the place, god of countries, god of the river, god of the mountain. "You're a God, obviously. You're speaking to me out of a burning bush. You seem to know my people. You're a divine figure. But which one are you?" That's what he's asking.
- 1.32** So, God's answer, "I am who I am," is saying my reality does not correspond to that kind of question. I am not one being among many. I'm not a thing or a being or an entity that you could categorize, you could identify, and that you could define. And this is the ground, everyone, for a very rich strain in our theological tradition. But, see, to

get this wrong is to walk right down the path to atheism because you read the atheists, both old and new, the classical atheist, Feuerbach and company, and the new atheist, Christopher Hitchens, they all make the same fundamental mistake, it seems to me. It's getting this wrong.

- 1.33** If God is construed as simply one being among many, before you know it, we're going to say that being is now irrelevant to me and, ultimately, that being doesn't even exist. But that's precisely what God is not on the biblical reading. I call this the Yeti theory of God, you know, Bigfoot. Some say there is a Bigfoot. Others say no, there is no Bigfoot. "Well, let's go look around and see if we can find him. Let's look for evidence of Bigfoot. I think there's some." "Oh, there's no evidence."
- 1.34** But that's what God isn't. God is not an item within the universe or above the universe alongside conditioned things. I am a human being. Okay, I'm defining my being that way. This is a studio. I'm defining the manner of this thing's being. "What's your name, God?" "I am who I am."
- 1.35** Thomas Aquinas very, very rarely—it's almost like he's made a mistake when he does it—very rarely refers to God as *Ens Summum*; that's Latin for 'highest being.' We're all beings, and there must be a highest being. *Ens Summum*. But Thomas doesn't use that term. When he speaks of God, he uses the term *Ipsium Esse*. *Esse* is an infinitive. It means 'to be.' *Ipsium* is 'itself.' God is 'to be itself,' not this or that, here or there, this name or that name. "I am who I am." I'm not a being, but being itself is the answer of the great catholic philosophical tradition grounded in this Exodus 3:14.
- 1.36** I'm describing it at this point. Can I move into a classical argument that would help us make sense of this? If you're saying, "Okay, I'm getting the words you're saying, but what makes you think this is a reality?" The traditions offered a number of arguments. I'm going to give you one that's an amalgam of a couple of arguments. I'll call it the argument from contingency, so keep this description of God in mind as I do this.
- 1.37** The argument from contingency begins with our ordinary experience. Let's say, this state of affairs right now, all of us in this space, in this studio with these lights and cameras, and we say, "Okay, this state of affairs exists." Yeah, no question about that, but does it have to exist? Does this state of affairs right now have to exist? Obviously, no. These things could all be taken away. Maybe my plane didn't take off yesterday from Minneapolis, and I never arrived here. Maybe you all got sick, and you couldn't make it. Maybe the studio burned down last night. There's nothing about the state of affairs that is necessary. It is, but it doesn't have to be.
- 1.38** What does that lead us to do? That leads us automatically—and this is behind every scientific move—it leads us to start looking for causes. It's not self-explanatory. I get that. So, what does explain the fact that this state of affairs obtains? Because the plane did leave from Minneapolis, got me here to Miami, and I got over here. Because you guys didn't get sick, and so you made your way to this place. Because the floor here is

stable, we can all be standing or sitting on it. Because there's an electrical grid somewhere that's keeping these lights and cameras going. Because there's oxygen in the air that we're able to breathe, that keeps us alive. All of those causes explain why this contingent state of affairs exists. And you say, "Okay, that explains it." If you got a curious mind because the curious mind says, "All the things I just mentioned, do they have to be here, or are they themselves contingent?" It's obvious, I hope.. The electrical grid that sustains the cameras and lights—does that have to be here? No, that's dependent upon all sorts of other factors. The stability of this floor—does that have to be there? No, it depends upon the stability of the earth. The oxygen we're breathing—does that have to be here? No, it depends upon a lot of things; one is the very gravity that keeps it close to the earth so we can breathe it.

- 1.39** Okay. have we explained this state of affairs? By no means, because all the things I just mentioned are themselves contingent—aren't they—on higher causes. So, think of the gravity holding the oxygen down so that we can breathe it. Where's that coming from but from the size of the planet, from its proximity to the sun, its point in the solar system? With every one of the things I've invoked, I could keep invoking further causes.
- 1.40** Now, what can't I do? What can't I do? I can't go on to infinity using that explanation, appealing endlessly to other contingent states of affairs. How come? Because then I never explain this contingent state of affairs that's right before my eyes. I'm still trying to explain why this obtains, and I've been appealing out, out, out, out to further and further contingent causes. What I can't do is go on to infinity. Therefore, there must exist some reality.
- 1.41** Listen now: Whose very nature is to be. There must exist, finally, some reality which is not contingent upon any cause beyond it but rather is its own explanation. Whose very nature is to be? Huh. "What's your name? When the Israelites ask me what's your name, what should I call you?" "I am who I am." My very nature is to be. Now, what I've done there is imitate our great tradition in correlating the biblical answer given to Moses to a philosophical argument but coming to the very same conclusion.
- 1.42** I can keep pointing to contingent causes and contingent states of affairs. Oh, there's this, there's that. It's of this size, that heat, that acceleration, this color, that history. I can point, point, point. But I have to come finally to that whose very nature is to be. Thomas Aquinas says, at the conclusion of that argument, "This is what all people call God." And I think the warrant is in this biblical passage, this strange name that Moses gives.
- 1.43** Now, from that standpoint, I'm going to do a little philosophy with you because I think the names we give to God follow very much from this basic idea I've been developing. Is God in this room? Yes. Yes. Why? Because the very being of this room, this very state of affairs, can be explained finally only through recourse to God. Working through all kinds of secondary causes, sure, but ultimately, God is responsible for everything that exists in this room.

- 1.44** Maybe there's no one here old enough to remember because I'm not old enough to remember the Baltimore catechism. The catholic church had a question: where is God? Answer: everywhere. Right, because Ipsum Esse, I am who I am, sustains all things. God's everywhere.
- 1.45** Is God in this room? No. Because everything in this room is a finite, contingent thing, and God isn't that. God is not this. He's not me, he's not the podium—God's not anything in this room. Saint Augustine said this. God is simultaneously "intimior intimo meo et superior summo meo." Lovely Latin. It's hard to translate directly, but something like this, "God is simultaneously closer to me than I am to myself and higher than the highest thing I could imagine." Now, we're talking. Now, we're talking.
- 1.46** See what happens. Watch this. Throughout the tradition, we take one side or the other of that. If you're a pantheist or just a nature mystic, you might take the intimior intimo meo side of that and say, "God is the world. God is nature." Or you're a deist. Ultimately, you're an atheist, but you say you're a deist. You say, "God is way up there, transcendent to us." The trick is to say, "No, no, they're both true at the same time." God is intimior intimo meo et superior summo meo at the same time.
- 1.47** Now, I'll put it in more biblical language. You can't avoid God, and you can't manipulate God. God is unavoidable and he's ungraspable. You can't hide from him, and you can't control him. The trick is—and this is now very close to the heart of the spiritual tradition—to live in that space where you stop trying to run from God, you stop trying to control God, and you fall in love with God. Now, we're getting to the heart of the matter there. We're getting from the more philosophical description to the way you live this out.
- 1.48** I think we look at the classical names of God. You can see them this way: there are anti-grasping names of God, and there are anti-hiding names of God. There are certain attributes of God that are meant to tell us, "Look, you can't control this reality," and others that tell us, "Look, you can't run from this reality." I want to walk through some of those with you.
- 1.49** Here's a term from Thomas Aquinas that I love, and I think he would say maybe it's the most important and fundamental of the divine attributes. He says, "God is marked by simplicity." God is simple. What does he mean? This depends upon Aquinas' metaphysics of essence and existence. I know that sounds highly technical; it really isn't. Aquinas would say that for every finite thing, there's a distinction between what that thing is and that the thing is.
- 1.50** So, this exists, this podium, but what it is, it's a being according to this mode. It's a podium-type being. I'm a human being. That's the modality of my being. And I actually exist. Essence and existence, but they're distinct. I'm a human being. It's a podium being. Saturn is a planetary being. So, what's God? What's your name? I'm posing it more philosophically, but what is God? To be God is to be to be because God's very

essence is his existence. That's what it means to be God. But see what happens. That means God is utterly simple. There are no distinctions that obtain within God. To be God is to be. Not this, that, up there, over here, over there. It's to be to be.

- 1.51** Now, why do I say that's an anti-grasping name? My new state is Minnesota now. If you go even north, where I am during the wintertime, you can experience a whiteout, sort of like this studio. When you're in a whiteout condition, you're driving along, and you can't see anything because the sky and the trees are obscured; the sky and the road is all just white. There are no landmarks. You can't see signs, you can't see trees. You can't really see the road. And under those conditions, you have to stop the car and get off the road because you're lost.
- 1.52** I'm dating myself now with a reference to a YouTube song, "Where the Streets Have No Name." Remember that song? That's an old mystical trope, by the way, to go to the place where the streets have no name. We all have the GPS, and so now we're so good at it. I can find every name. There's a satellite up there that's going to send to my little machine here the streets, so I can make my way from—I'm so in control with a thing like this. But with God, that's completely inappropriate. God is like a whiteout. There's no traction my mind can get.
- 1.53** I see. What kind of being is God? He's not that type of being. Okay, that gives me some traction, a foothold. Oh, he's there or not there. Okay. Most of our knowledge is by way of that comparison, contrasting, it's this, not that. But when it comes to God, in his simplicity, I can't get my mind around God. Read the high mystics on this, where you leave behind imagery. You leave behind language. You leave behind even the highest concepts.
- 1.54** Saint John of the Cross, not only one of the great Spanish poets but the greatest Catholic mystic, talks about the dark night of the senses and the dark night of the soul. That's not depression. People read it as I'm falling into depression. That's not what it means at all. It means I've darkened my senses because that's not where God is. I've darkened even the images of my mind. I've darkened even the highest things in my soul because God lies beyond all of that. So, the simplicity of God is an anti-grasping name. No traction.
- 1.55** Here's a second one. Aquinas, along with most of our great traditions, says that God is infinite. Again, you see why. *Finis* in Latin means a 'border' or a 'line,' an 'end.' So, if something is finite, it's got borders around it, which is why it can be defined. I can name its borders. I can define you. What's your name? What kind of being are you, etcetera. With God, none of that obtains. I can't set a border or a limit. I can't define God. God's being is unlimited.
- 1.56** You know what's lovely here? It's an anti-grasping name, so don't try to control God, but see how alluring that is. Some of the high mystics say that what we realize in heaven is how incomprehensible God is. Isn't that lovely? So, I'm trying to make that

case here with you that God is incomprehensible. Yeah, I get that. But in heaven, I'm really going to grasp it. But see, that means there's infinite exploration possible. It never comes to an end. I never come to a finis or to a limit of God's being. So, God is simple. God is infinite. What follows from that?

1.57 God is one, the unity of God. You see why. The minute I say, "There's this and there's that; there are two of them," what have I done? I've defined each one in relation to the other. I've set a limit. A is not B. B is not A. The minute you say 'not' in there, you're setting a limit, and there are no limits in God. So, there can't be two infinities. There can't be two absolute simplicities. There can't be two or more unconditioned sources of existence.

1.58 Now, the Bible. "Hear, O Israel, the Lord your God is Lord alone!" The great Shema prayer of Deuteronomy, Chapter 6. It's the foundation, in many ways, of Old Testament biblical religion. "Hear, O Israel, the Lord your God is Lord alone!" See, all forms of polytheism are saying something true. What polytheism is stating is the omnipresence of God, that God is in and through all things, but it's doing it very awkwardly. Israel had to shout. It still does; it shouts it in prayer every day. "Hear, O Israel, the Lord your God is Lord alone!" There's only one unconditioned source of existence.

1.59 Another one: we speak of the self-sufficiency of God. Does God need the world? No. God is God. God is the sheer act of to be itself. God's utterly perfect. God has no need of anything. Now, I'll come back to that. That's good news for us. I'll come back to it. That's good news for us that God doesn't need the world; God is self-sufficient.

1.60 Aquinas used that lovely term in his Latin. God is "Actus Purus." Pure actuality. Actus translates the word 'energia' in Greek, which I love. Energy. What is God? God is pure energy, the pure energy of existence, the source of anything that exists that we can see around us and measure. But God is Actus Purus. He's pure energy, the pure source of existence. This is a term that people balk at, but they shouldn't.

1.61 Aquinas says that God has no real relation to the world. What he doesn't mean is that God doesn't care about the world. It doesn't mean that at all. What he means is God is not dependent upon the world. So, right now, we all have a real relationship with each other in Thomas's language, meaning I'm dependent upon you, and I am because I'm looking at you right now. I'm speaking to you. You're dependent upon me in the measure that you're listening to me. I'm dependent upon this room. The room is affected by me, and this is the way things are. But God has no real relation to the world. God doesn't need the world. God does not depend in any way upon the world. That's part of the ungraspable self-sufficiency of God. Okay?

1.62 So, you say, all right, I get it. I get that, but doesn't that turn God into something fearsome and distant and disconnected I can't grasp, so I'll just give up? Remember Augustine? "Intimior intimo meo et superior summo meo." I've been talking here about

the superior summo meo side of it. He's beyond whatever I can imagine, but don't forget intimior intimo meo. He's closer to me than I am to myself.

- 1.63** So, what words come to mind? All the omni words we use of God. So, where's God? Everywhere. God is omnipresent. Aquinas says, "God is in all things by essence, presence, and power, and most intimately so." That's a lovely phrase. I've used that for prayer often. God is in all things by essence, presence, and power, and then he says "intimae"—most intimately so. Of course, God is in all things. There's no place to run.
- 1.64** I'll speak later about the prophet Jonah. What was Jonah's problem? He thought he could run away from God. Literally, God says, go East by land; Jonah goes West by sea. So, I can avoid the press of God. Give it up. God's unavoidable. He's omnipresent. It doesn't mean that—I remember years ago when I was teaching at a seminary, a student who was coming out of a science background said, "So, God's kind of like a gas that pervades all." I said, "No, God's not like a gas," because that would just be one more item within the world, one more feature of the world. When you say God's omnipresent, you mean he's the sustaining source of the being of all things.
- 1.65** Aquinas talks about creatio continua, 'continual creation.' Herbert McCabe who is a contemporary theologian, says, "God sustains the world the way a singer sustains a song." It's lovely, isn't it? Think of a singer sustaining a song. That's how God sustains the universe. He's omnipresent.
- 1.66** Furthermore, he's omnipotent. We say God's all-powerful. Remember the old sophomoric thing? Can God make a rock so big that even he can't lift it? When you say God is omnipotent, don't think of it as he must be the strongest being around; he's the strongest being among beings. No, it means that God presses upon all things with his power, and his power here is a sustaining power to sustain the world in existence. God can do all that's real. Yeah, sure, because God's the source of the reality of the finite world. So, he's omnipotent.
- 1.67** And then, finally, we say that God is omniscient, all-knowing. Now, it doesn't mean you're smart. That person's smarter. Einstein is super smart. And then, God must be the smartest of them all. He's the smartest dude around. No, now I'm making God into a categorical thing. When I say that God is omniscient, what do I mean? I mean that he knows the whole world into existence.
- 1.68** So, right now, I'm taking in the information from this room. If someone tomorrow says, "Hey, how many people were there for that Peterson lecture?" I'll say, "Oh, there are about 20 people." Yeah, because I'm taking in information passively from the world and reporting it. That's never true of God, is it? Because God doesn't derive knowledge from the world. Rather, he knows the world into being. In that sense, he's omniscient. He knows all things.
- 1.69** Can I give you, I think, the coolest analogy, actually? All analogies limp, and this one limps, too, but it's a good analogy, I think, for everything I've been trying to say about

God and the world here. I think the best comparison would be an author-to-text . Think especially of a big, rambling novel, like the Lord of the Rings. Think of Tolkien's relationship, the author's relationship, to the Lord of the Rings. Does Tolkien know everything in the Lord of the Rings? Of course, he does. He wrote it. So, all the plot, the subplot, the major characters, the minor characters, this invented world, every comma, every period, every semicolon. Of course, he does because he's the creator of the totality of that novel.

- 1.70** Does everything in that novel reflect his mind and purpose? Yeah, everything does because he created all of it from nothing. That world didn't exist. And then, Tolkien thought it into being, brought it into being. If you want to understand Tolkien, look all through that novel, and you'll see him reflected in every place.
- 1.71** But is Tolkien a character in the novel? No. There's Gandalf, there's Frodo, there's Bilbo, there's the Orcs, and there's Aragorn. Oh, and there's Tolkien. No, he's not a character in the novel. The author never appears as an item within the story, but he's the great omniscient, omnipotent, omnipresent author of the entire story. Now, it seems to me we're getting much closer to what the great tradition means by God and our relationship to God. Don't try to grasp him, but don't try to hide from him.
- 1.72** How about this from Psalm 139? "Lord, you search me, and you know me. You discern my purpose from afar." Of course, of course. God is knowing me from the inside. How about this? " If I climb to the heavens, you're there. I go to the sea's furthest end. Even there, your right hand holds me up." Yeah, because God's omnipresent and God's omnipotent. I can't run away from God.
- 1.73** That line, in a way, is the sinner's lament. "Where can I get away from you? How do I escape from you?" "You can't. You can't." "Okay, so I'll try to control you." "No, no, no. Don't try that game either." God can neither be manipulated nor hidden from. That's what we're driving at.
- 1.74** Let me say a couple of things, as I bring this first lecture to a close, about creation. I've been describing it really already. We speak about creation ex nihilo, that God makes the world from nothing. Do you see why we have to say that? Because in so many of the myths and legends of the ancient world, creation comes through a primal act of violence. One set of gods defeats another set of gods, and often, from the severed body parts of the defeated gods, the world is made up. There's usually something like primal violence at the heart of these myths.
- 1.75** But Ipsum Esse, there's no rival to ipsum esse. "Hear, O Israel, the Lord your God is Lord alone!" There's nothing outside of his aegis and control. Therefore, God is not wrestling anything into existence, but he creates from nothing. Furthermore, it means there is literally nothing standing between us and God. It doesn't mean we're God, but it means there's no buffer zone; there's no intermediary between us and God. But rather, when I find that place in me, where I am here and now being created by God—that's Thomas

Merton's definition of contemplative prayer, by the way, finding that place in me, where I am here and now being created by God, I find my peace. I find the right relationship to God. That's the spiritual implication of creation from nothing.

- 1.76** Look what else has to be true. I find the place in me, where I am here and now being created by God. What else have I found? The place where you are here and now being created by God, and where you are, and where you are, and Saint Francis—Brother Sun and Sister Moon. That's not just high poetry; that's rather precise metaphysics. Yes, the sun and moon are brother and sister to us because we're all ontological siblings. We're all coming forth from this great singer who is God.
- 1.77** We're all part of the song that God is continually sustaining, which means we're like notes in a score. What we don't want is the cacophony. What's sin but the notes now at odds with each other; the notes taking upon themselves to compose the score. No, no, let God sing his song through us. The interconnectedness of all things is really key to this idea.
- 1.78** I hope the thing you're seeing in all this presentation is the way the catholic tradition weaves together its highest metaphysical language and its most intimate spiritual language. One of the dangers—and here I agree with Hans Urs von Balthasar, one of my favorite contemporary theologians—he said that it was the divorce between theology and spirituality that was the greatest tragedy. He said the greatest tragedy in the history of the church is that we separated those two things out. I would say the deeper you go into the metaphysics of God and creation, the deeper you go into the spirituality that ought to be central to our lives.

Lecture 2: Right Praise and Sacrifice

At a glance — Right praise and sacrifice.

- 2.1 We come to some clarity about the God we're talking about. The source of all existence, I am who I am, Ipsum Esse, the one in whom essence and existence coincide. Knowing all the time that even as I use that language, it's meant in a way to obscure things.
- 2.2 Think of—Catholics know about this—the incense we use at Mass sometimes. When you put smoke around the altar. It's got a lot of different symbolic meanings, but one of them is it's meant to block things. It's meant to get in your eyes and maybe irritate you a bit, and then you can't see what's going on. Well, in a way, theological language is like that. It's a bit like sacred incense. So, it'll prevent us from this grasping tendency.
- 2.3 But having come, anyway, to some greater clarity about God, we now look at this opening text of the entire Bible dealing with creation. Here's the question I want to ask before we even get to the text. Why would God create at all? Ipsum Esse—the sheer act of being itself. Actus Purus—the totality and summation of what it means to be. God has everything possible. So, why would God create? It's a puzzling question. It's been answered in a lot of different ways over the centuries.
- 2.4 Many times, some version of God creates out of need. God needs something from the world. He needs that relationship. The great Catholic tradition has said from the beginning, "No, no. God has no need of the world." And you say, "That's off-putting." No, no. It's the hinge in many ways upon which the whole spiritual life turns. Because God doesn't need the world, God is capable of utterly loving the world.
- 2.5 Now, to get that, we have to understand love is not a feeling, primarily. Love means to will the good of the other. If I can intensify that, to will the good of the other as other. Most of us are sinners. We're self-absorbed. Even if I'm kind to you or I'm just to you, it's often out of self-interest. I'll be kind to you that you might be kind to me. I'll be just to you so that you might be just to me in return. But that isn't love. That's an indirect egotism. To love, let me say it again, is to will the good of the other as other.
- 2.6 It's to break free of the black hole quality of the ego. You know how the black hole draws everything into itself, including light? Well, that's what the sinful ego is like. It draws the world into itself. So, the world exists on my terms. Love is to break free of that black hole of the ego and to will the good of the other as other.
- 2.7 God, we are told in the New Testament, is love. The God who doesn't need the world can only love the world. That's the point. Why do we exist? Not because God needs us. Not because he's going to manipulate us to achieve something. No. He wills the good of the world. The first Vatican Council put it this way, "God creates simply to manifest his glory." What's his glory? His glory is his loving nature. So, God manifests his love.

- 2.8** I love the fact that God doesn't need the world. I love the fact that it's Ipsum Esse who gives rise to the world because it means God is not going to manipulate us. He only wants what is for our good. A very important point. And how easily, fellow sinners, we fall off of that line. We forget that principle because we're so accustomed to living in our ordinary experience that we're not surrounded by people who are marked by complete love. They're marked by manipulation and so on. So, we naturally project that onto God. Not the case. God creates out of the sheerest love.
- 2.9** All right, with that in mind, let's look at this famous text, one of the fundamental texts of the entire Western tradition. "In the beginning, when God created the heavens and the earth, the earth was a formless void and darkness covered the face of the deep, while the wind from God swept over the face of the waters. Then God said, 'Let there be light,' and there was light. And God saw the light was good."
- 2.10** What I mentioned at the end of the last lecture, we have to keep in mind here. There's not a trace of violence in this creation account. Not a trace of conquering some extraneous element, some enemy or rival to God. Not through violence does God create, but rather through an act of speech and out of the sheerest love. It's a non-violent act of creation.
- 2.11** I'm anticipating here a little bit of my very last lecture when we get to the sermon on the mount. We find in Jesus, especially that language about enemy love, loving even your enemies. That's not just a new moral theory. It's grounded in this deep metaphysics. "Be perfect as your heavenly Father is perfect," says Jesus. What a strange thing to say the more you think about it. "Be perfect as your heavenly Father is perfect." In other words, be in love as he is and as he loves. It's on display right here from the beginning. It's through speech and in love, not through violence, that God makes the world.
- 2.12** I mentioned the ancient myths, but look, it comes right up through our time. How often — think of almost every movie you ever see—how often is order restored through some great act of violence? We take it for granted that you need violence to restore order, but the primordial order of the world is not established through violence but through intelligence and love, an act of speech offered in love. I love that. It's a very important point.
- 2.13** Now, the formless void that Genesis talks about here at the beginning, the wind sweeping over the face of the waters, there's a lovely and strange Hebrew term that's being translated here, and it's *tohu wa-bohu* in the Hebrews. It means something like the 'primal chaos' or the 'watery chaos.' We mustn't read that as some rival to God. Watch God hovering over it, God having complete lordship over it.
- 2.14** But it is an anticipation of something that runs right through the Bible, Old Testament and New. It stands, if you want, for resistance to God. It stands for the sinful rebellion against God. The ancient Hebrews, like a lot of ancient peoples, were afraid of the

depths of the water. If they traveled by sea, which they did, they often hugged the shore; they wouldn't go out into the depths—and imagine with the leaky boats they had. So, the sea, the primal deep, the chaos, often functions as a symbol of negativity, what stands opposed to God. Watch it reasserting itself in the flood of Noah, in the Red Sea that has to be divided, even in the water on which Jesus walks, showing his Lordship over the *tohu wa-bohu*. Just want to draw your attention to that.

- 2.15** Now, God makes light first and finds it good. "And then God said, 'Let there be a dome in the midst of the water. Let it separate the waters from the waters. And so it happened. Evening came, morning followed. Then the third day, God said, 'Let the waters under the sky be gathered,' et cetera. Evening came, morning followed, the fourth day.
- 2.16** What are we seeing here? I think Catholics will notice this or people with a higher liturgical tradition. It's something like a liturgical procession. Coming forth in this orderly way from God. All the elements that make up the world coming forth in this ordered liturgical procession. Who comes at the end? We come. The human being is created at the end, the last in the procession. Who comes last in liturgical procession? The one who is going to lead the praise. So, if all the ministers are processing in for Mass, one after the other in their orderly manner, and at the end comes the priest or the bishop, the one who's going to lead the praise, now we've cracked part of the code of the Bible.
- 2.17** Watch something. Sky and mountains and sea and animals and so on—what are all these things that come forth? Well, somewhere in the ancient world, those things were worshiped, weren't they? Go through the mythologies and religions of the ancient world. All the things mentioned here were, at some point, worshiped. What's the author of Genesis saying? Don't worship these things. Are they good? Yep. Each time, they're created, God found them good. And God found them good. And God found them good. They're good, but they're not God.
- 2.18** They were worshiped in different ways, but the author is saying, "Don't worship them"—rather, what?—let all of these things become part of a great chorus of praise to God led by human beings. What's the human role vis-à-vis the rest of creation? Not domination. So, that brings us to a contemporary place. We're not meant to dominate creation. It's so super important to see that in the biblical reading, it's never the human role to dominate creation or be the Lord of Creation in that negative way, but rather to serve creation as the leader of right praise.
- 2.19** Now, watch this. I would argue, I go so far as to say, it perhaps is the master theme of the entire Bible. When we stand in the attitude of right praise toward God, and we lead creation together with us in that praise, the world is as God wants it to be. Watch when Israel goes wrong, and I would challenge you to find any exception to this. Israel always goes wrong when some form of false worship comes into play. We might see that as just a little minor problem off to the side—the real serious business is the moral

degradation of the people. Always behind moral degradation is a more fundamental problem. Bad praise. Israel praises in the wrong way. Trouble ensues. When they get back on line with right praise, the world coheres. That's a basic biblical intuition.

- 2.20** Let me say a couple of things more about worship. Our word 'adoration,' when we adore God, comes from two Latin words: ad ora. It means 'to the mouth of.' It means 'to be mouth to mouth.' The very beginning of the Song of Songs is, "Let him kiss me with the kiss of his mouth." It's a love poem. It's like a call-and-response love poem. Well, all the mystics have read that, though, as the soul calling out to God. That's adoration language. "Kiss me with the kiss of his mouth" means ad ora; I'm mouth to mouth. It means rightly aligned unto God.
- 2.21** Now, watch what happens. When we're in that attitude, we find harmony within us. The image I've used for years here is the image of the rose window from the Gothic churches. Think of the North Rose at Notre Dame. When Notre Dame was on fire, I knew it very well from my studies in Paris. It was breaking my heart because that window was so important to me. Thank God it survived the fire.
- 2.22** At the center of the rose is always a depiction of Christ. He might be the baby in his mother's lap because it is Notre Dame, Our Lady's Cathedral. But in the very heart of the window is Christ. And then, wheeling around it in all these ordered patterns are the other medallions, the French call them. Then, they're connected by spokes to each other and to the center. We look at that, and we say, "What a beautiful picture." And it is, but it's singing to our souls because that's an image of the rightly ordered soul, or the rightly ordered city, or the rightly ordered world. When Christ is central, when adoratio is happening, worship is happening, then the rose window obtains inside of me.
- 2.23** So, think of all the elements in the rose: my mind, my will, my passions, my personal life, my public life, my friendships, my entertainment, all the things that make me up. When I'm worshiping, I'm aligned to the highest good of God, and then all of that tends to fall into harmony. I've known, in the course of my life, I think, a handful of people who really are saints. And that's the mark they have. There's an extraordinary harmony about them, a symphonic quality. Their life hangs together.
- 2.24** Kierkegaard, the great philosopher, said, "A saint is someone whose life is about one thing." It's a very cool definition because it doesn't mean that there's a monotony to the saint's life. It means everything in the saint is gathered around the One. That's the right praise; that's adoratio.
- 2.25** The other word that's interesting here is our word worship in English. Worship comes from an older English term, 'worthship.' What's of the highest worth to you? Paul Tillich, the theologian, said, "Everything you need to know about a person, you can discover by asking one question: what do you worship?" I've always thought that's dead right. Because we all do. We all worship something. Something is of the highest

value to us. There's some center of gravity. Now, it might be wealth and power and honor. It could be your country. It could be your family, whatever it is. Listen, it could be any creature under heaven. It could be any of these creatures.

- 2.26** If you make those your highest value, you will fall apart. The harmony of the rose window will become—it'll disintegrate. The symphony will become a cacophony. And again, fellow sinners in this room, we all know what that feels like when we're at odds with ourselves. My mind says this, but my will says that. This feeling goes that way; the other feeling goes that way. My soul says one thing; my body says something else. That's the disintegrated self. The point here at the very beginning of the Bible is you will find integration in the measure that you worship God alone. You're in the stance of adoration, mouth to mouth, and you will create harmony around you as you do that.
- 2.27** The reason we put halos on the saints is because they become luminous to others, don't they? When someone is really integrated, when they're in the stance of right praise, their life's about one thing; they tend to radiate harmony around them. That's the way it's supposed to work from the beginning. That's the biblical vision.
- 2.28** What goes wrong? Bad praise. And up and down the Bible, it's the same problem. I take a creature and turn that creature into my summum bonum. I treat a creature as though it's the creator, and everything else will flow from that. That's why, at the very beginning of the Bible, there's an examination of conscience going on. How do you stand vis-à-vis this question of right praise?
- 2.29** Let's go back and talk a little bit about what goes wrong, the false worship. So, the Lord says to Adam and Eve in the garden, "Eat of all the trees." And I think this has been overlooked too much in the great tradition. Prior to the prohibition, there's the great permission. God says, "Eat of all the trees in the garden." What does God want? He doesn't benefit from us in any way. He's not trying to gain something from us. He wants us to be alive. Gloria Dei homo vivens.
- 2.30** So, the trees in the garden—the church fathers read it this way beautifully—the trees stand for art and science and politics and friendship and the building of cities and all the things that make life wonderful. God says, "Go, go." This view of God—the God of the Bible is censorious and difficult, and always making moral demands on us. The fundamental vision here is one of the great divine permission that God glories in our being fully alive.
- 2.31** But then, we do come to the famous prohibition. The one tree I don't want you to eat from is this Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil. And you say, "Is God just being capricious and difficult here and trying to make life hard for us?" The Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil—that means the prerogative that must belong to God alone, which is the determination of good and evil. God, the summum bonum, the highest good, is himself the ground and source of value. All things that are valuable in

the world reflect God's beauty and God's value. God, in his own being, determines what is good and what is evil.

- 2.32** What's the one thing we can't do? What's the one thing we should not do? Make ourselves the criterion of good and evil. I'm going to decide what's right and what's wrong. I'm going to worship what I want. I'm going to do whatever I want. I'm the creator of value around here. And the roots of this are very ancient because the author of Genesis knew about it, but they come right up massively into our own time.
- 2.33** What is Friedrich Nietzsche—to my mind, the most influential philosopher of the 19th century— what is Nietzsche saying? God is dead, and we've killed him. And once God's out of the picture, then what? I decide. The Übermensch, the Superman, the Superperson, becomes the criterion of value.
- 2.34** Go into the 20th century now. Look at Jean-Paul Sartre, the founder of existentialism. How come he calls it existentialism? His answer was, "Because existence precedes essence," a fancy way of saying my freedom comes first. My existence, my mind, my will, my freedom comes first. And then, on that basis, I determine my essence, who I am, what I'm all about, or what I stand for. Those are as old as this text, that problem. That's called eating from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil, irrigating to oneself the prerogative of determining good and evil.
- 2.35** When that happens, what? We're expelled from the garden because God is having a smith, and God is getting—no, no, no. That's to psychologize these texts. It's a spiritual physics. Right praise, worship, leads to harmony, symphony, and radiates around to the benefit of the world. Bad praise leads to disintegration, the desert. And again, these are desert people. So, if you want to reach for an image for lifelessness, cut off from the source of life. It's the desert. God's not being capricious here. It's spiritual physics. If you start worshiping the wrong way, you will be led by a very short road into the desert.
- 2.36** What's the Bible all about? It's the story of how is God trying to lead his people back to the right praise, how to lead them out of the desert. And I think, when I mentioned early on about themes, patterns, trajectories—that's one of the most fundamental.
- 2.37** Let me say a quick word before I get to Abraham, which is the next text I really want to sink into. A little bit about a few texts that intervene. This is Chapter 3. We hear about the creation and the fall. But then, between 3 and 12, that's when Abraham appears. We see beautifully compact form, almost like all forms of human depravity and dissolution.
- 2.38** We see, for example, the Story of Noah. What's happening in Noah? The *tohu wa-bohu* is back, the primal chaos that thwarts God, that stands against God's creative intentions for us. The *tohu wa-bohu* is back, so the floodwaters, and how floodwaters terrified ancient people, they terrify us to this day. There's something uniquely destructive

about floodwater. Well, that's the power of sin. It's when bad praise is spread broadly upon the Earth, it will lead to this dissolution.

- 2.39** What does God do? What he always does in the Bible—he sends a rescue operation. What's the Ark of Noah? God preserving a microcosm of his good order. So, think of the order at the beginning of Genesis, all the animals and the plants and all that coming forth from God. Well, the floodwaters—that's the power of sin that leads to dissolution, destruction. But God provides this rescue operation on which this little microcosm of his good order is preserved. What's Noah's Ark, therefore? It's a floating temple. Human beings leading all of creation in right praise. That's the world as a temple. That's the whole world as a place of rightly ordered worship.
- 2.40** Sin leads to the dissolution of that; it leads to *tohu wa-bohu*, but God preserves this little microcosm, this little floating temple where God's right order is preserved. Watch this motif of water rescue throughout the Bible. Go back to Notre Dame for a second, that place I love so much. Situated there on the Ile de Cite, in the River Seine, the great flying buttresses coming out the side, looking for all the world like oars. The central part of that church is called a nave, from 'novice' or 'ship.' The Gothic cathedrals especially, but all churches, are meant to be little Noah's arks. They're meant to be a place where something of God's good order is preserved, and what's preserved at the heart of every church? Worship, worth-ship, right praise.
- 2.41** When people gather in the church, and they're ordered to the summum bonum, to the highest good, they sing together in harmony—I always find that interesting about singing. Most of us are pretty bad singers, but you get a whole church full of people singing, they sound pretty good, don't they? But it's not true that if you had five bad basketball players and you got them all together, they'd be a great team. It doesn't work that way. But somehow, with singing, it does. And I always think now, when you sing at church, you sing at Mass, that's not really decorative. That's expressive of this very deep truth.
- 2.42** What do we call upon also during the liturgy but the word of God? As we hear the cacophonous sounds of all kinds of words around us, we come onto that great ship, and we hear the word of God. We sing together as we become rightly ordered. So, that's the motif all through the Bible and then all through the tradition of the church. It's how do we get the world back on line?
- 2.43** Look, too, at the narratives about Cain and Abel. So, the first murderer, the one whose jealousy leads him to this murderous act, killing his own brother—Cain is described as the founder of cities. Saint Augustine found this extremely interesting. Augustine knew that in ancient Rome, in that myth story of Romulus and Remus, the founders of Rome, Romulus kills Remus. He's a fratricide as well. Yet Romulus is held up as the great heroic founder of the city of Rome. But in the Bible, Cain, the fratricide, is also identified as the founder of cities, but he's seen as a very negative figure. What's the difference?

- 2.44 The world really has no problem with violence at the heart of order. Remember that old theme we just rehearsed? In the old myths, very often, order comes through violence. The same idea there. Romulus is a hero because he found the city of Rome through this primal act of murder. But in the Bible, Cain stands for the haunting of human order by violence.
- 2.45 What's Jesus come to do, by the way, but establish this Kingdom of God that's not like the cities founded by Cain. See, there's the point there. In that wonderful story of the Tower of Babel, again, we're going from the fall up to Abraham, but we're looking at forms of human dysfunction—Tower of Babel. We want to build a tower that goes all the way up to heaven, grasping at God, not worshiping God. Notice, please, when you're worshiping God, what aren't you doing? You're clearly not fleeing from God, but you're also not trying to grasp at God. Now, we're talking. Now, we found that middle ground, if you want.
- 2.46 In the attitude of worship, we neither manipulate nor flee, but we're in the right order. Tower of Babel, I'm trying to grasp at God. I'm using unity so everyone has the same language, but not for a good purpose. I'm using unity for an oppressive, imperialistic purpose, which is why God scatters—divides the languages. Again, not being capricious, but trying to limit the damage being done by sin.
- 2.47 So, Genesis lays out beautifully what we're supposed to be, what's happened to us, and then the effects of what's happened to us. But then, commencing in Chapter 12 is the great rescue operation of Israel. God will rescue the situation. How? By forming a holy people. Noah's Ark anticipates it, but it begins really in Chapter 12 with the formation of a holy people.
- 2.48 What's the mark of this people? We're looking now at Genesis, Chapter 12, as the story of Abraham commences. "Now the Lord said to Abraham, 'Go from your country and your kindred and your father's house to the land that I will show you. I will make you a great nation. I will bless you and make your name great so that you will be a blessing.'" It begins with the hearing of a voice. "Hear, O Israel, the Lord your God is Lord alone." That's the Old Testament. Paul, the New Testament: "Faith comes from hearing." We hear all kinds of voices from the ordinary world, from the world of categorical experience. I've heard all kinds of voices today. I hear voices on the radio, TV, Internet. Voices, voices. What's The voice?
- 2.49 Think again, Ipsum Esse, in relation to all the particular beings of the world. God, in relation to all that exists in the contingent finite order. How do I hear that voice? The rescue operation begins with someone, finally, Abraham, someone, finally, who hears the voice. The voice of the Unconditioned. The voice of Ipsum Esse, the voice of the Creator. Is it mediated by ordinary voices? Sometimes, sometimes. Is it something startling and strange? Yeah, look at all the mystics. Look at all the prophets. Does God sometimes speak literally in a voice? Well, the prophets will say that, and some of the mystical figures, even Mother Teresa of Calcutta, said at one key point in your life, she

literally heard a voice telling her what to do. But I think, typically, it's being used here in a more symbolic way, of hearing the summons that comes from the depth, from Ipsum Esse, not from any of the beings in the world that represent the interests of the world, but from God.

- 2.50** What's one of the clearest indications of this voice? In our great tradition, it's the voice of the conscience. John Henry Newman, a 19th-century theologian, said the conscience "is the aboriginal vicar of Christ in the soul." It's lovely. He, as a Catholic, believed the Pope was the vicar of Christ, but the aboriginal, the more fundamental vicar of Christ, the voice of the Unconditioned, the voice of Ipsum Esse, the voice of God, is the conscience.
- 2.51** How about that story of Elijah? When he sees the fire and the earthquake and all these marvelous manifestations, but God was not in any of those. But then, he hears a tiny, whispering voice, and he covers his head and goes to listen. What is that but the voice of the conscience that echoes deep down inside of us? It's the voice of the summum bonum, the highest good. The world is full of good things, and the voices of the world can be full of good suggestions to us. But we sense in these powerful moments, especially in conscience, when the summum bonum is speaking to us, the summum bonum, the highest good, when God speaks to us.
- 2.52** The rescue operation commences when someone is finally willing to listen to that voice. Now, again, I'm sure most of us—none of us in this room have literally heard the voice of God the way one of the prophets did. But I think you all know what I'm talking about when we start speaking of this deep communication. To do the right thing, or more importantly, to be the right person. Does that make sense? When you know, "I've got a decision to make here about the person I'm going to be." That's the voice of your conscience.
- 2.53** And then, it'll manifest itself in particular decisions. Like, "Don't do that," or "You should do this." But fundamentally, it's this call to be a good person, to be a person of righteousness. Jesus speaks about being single-hearted and hungry and thirsting for righteousness. That's what he means.
- 2.54** Abraham is someone now who heard that voice and decided, "I'm going to follow it." And with that, the rescue operation begins. With that, the holy people of Israel is formed. It's marvelous how God decided to do it, isn't it?—not through a direct intervention but by a formation of a people formed after his own heart.
- 2.55** Now, having seen this, we should immediately see why Abraham is called our father in faith. And, everybody, if you take nothing away from my lectures but take this, I'd be happy. When you read the new atheists and critics of religion today, what do you often read? "Oh, faith. It's a bunch of old superstition. It's accepting things on the basis of no evidence. It's Bronze Age mythology. Get your heads out of the ground and believe in the sophisticated science. You people of faith—" That's not what faith means. That's

not what faith means—accepting nonsense on the basis of no evidence. None of our great figures would ever say that. That's called credulity or superstition, naïveté. Nobody wants that. None of that belongs in the great religious and spiritual tradition.

- 2.56** What does faith mean in the Bible? It means this. Abraham is our father in faith. It means the willingness to hear, follow, and accept the demand of that voice. That's faith. That's faith. By definition, am I in control of this process? No. That's why it's not knowledge in that scientific way. I put things under a microscope, or I look through a telescope, or I do experiments. That's me in command. With faith, it never works that way because it's God summoning us. God's summoning us from the depth of our being to be a person of righteousness, and when I respond and say, "Yes, yes, I'm going to walk that path," now I'm a person of faith.
- 2.57** That's why, more than ever, the world needs faith today. It doesn't mean credulity. It means an attitude of trusting acceptance in the presence of the voice of the Unconditional, I would say. Trusting acceptance. I love it when people say, "Oh, religion, people of faith. It's for simple-minded people or people that are hyper-conservative and not very confident or adventurous." On the contrary, it seems to me. People who are totally at home in this world and the values of this world. Ho-hum. Bore me to death with that. The really interesting people, it seems to me, are people of faith who have heard the voice of God and are willing to respond to it. Those are people who are really ready to go on an adventure.
- 2.58** Think of all those stories. Tolkien, again, comes to mind: Bilbo or Frodo running off on an adventure. It means being drawn out of the cozy comfort of your little hobbit hole. The hobbit hole there symbolizes ordinary experience, my ordinary life. It's being drawn up out of that onto this great adventure. So again, what does he say to Abraham? "Go from your country, your kindred, your father's house, to the land that I will show you." Dangerous. Yep, yep. Faith is a dangerous path. It just is because it means I'm trusting. I don't see clearly at all, but I'm trusting the voice.
- 2.59** To be a good person of righteousness, what will that entail? I don't know what's going to be asked of me, but I'm going to go. I'm going to go. That's the attitude of faith. It's got nothing to do with conservatism or cowardice or staying at home and accepting my own little private opinions. It's the contrary of that. Listen, now, as the Lord goes on. We see here what follows from faith. "I'm the Lord who brought you from the Ur of the Chaldeans to give you this land to possess. Look toward the heavens and count the stars if you're able to count them. So shall your descendants be."
- 2.60** Can I give you a principle, everybody, in the spiritual order? When you receive grace, a gift from God, and then you contrive a way to give that grace away, to return it to God, so to speak, it will return to you multiplied. Let me say it again. When you receive grace, you don't cling to it and make it your own little possession, but you contrive a way to give it back to God, you will find the grace—what does Jesus say?—increasing in you thirty, sixty, and a hundredfold. That's the principle.

- 2.61** John Paul II called it the law of the gift. It's simply that your being increases in the measure that you give it away. Go to the spiritual bank with that. Put that on your computer screen. That's the spiritual life. Your being increases in the measure that you give it away. Your trust in God will lead to what? "Look at the heavens and count the stars if you're able to count them. So shall your descendants be." What follows from faith is life, an abundant life.
- 2.62** Turn that principle around now. When you receive grace and cling to it and say, "I'm going to make this my own," what happens? "You'll lose the little you think you have," says Jesus. Or look at the parable of the prodigal son, the father who represents God, and the son says, "Give me my share. Give it to me." What happened to him? He fritters it away in very short order. Before you know it, he's got nothing. That's how it goes in the spiritual order. When you take the grace and you try to make it your possession, you lose it. But when you accept grace and now give it back to God, you give it away as a gift, you follow in trust the voice, life increases in you thirty, sixty, and a hundredfold. That's the wager of the whole Bible.
- 2.63** The spiritual life is like riding a wave. It's a dangerous proposal because the world's always saying to us, "No, no, no, hang on to what you got. Stay in Ur of the Chaldeans. Look, you're 75 years old, Abraham, and your family's there. What are you doing? You're following this crazy voice to go across the desert? Are you out of your mind?" That's always the voice of the world. "Hang on to it." isn't this wonderful? Because it's literally the case that all of us here, believers in the God of Abraham, are the descendants of this man. We're one of those stars that the Lord pointed to. Right here, right now, we're descendants from this man's willingness to follow the voice, to give away the grace. That's the principle. That's the principle.
- 2.64** When you do that, you breathe life all around you. I love that. I came across this line not long ago. It said, "There are two types of people in the world: those who suck air out of a room and those who breathe life into a room." That's pretty much right. That's what we're talking about here. A person of faith is someone who breathes life into a room. It happens by following the voice.
- 2.65** In the time I've got in this lecture, I want to go from that call of Abraham to one of the most dreadful texts in the Bible. I found, after many years of preaching and teaching, it's a text that really bothers people. It gets deep down into their souls, and they wrestle with it, and they're angry about it. I'm talking about Genesis Chapter 22. It's called the Akedah. That's the Hebrew for the "binding of Isaac," the sacrifice of Isaac.
- 2.66** You know the setting. We just heard the promise made to Abraham from Ipsum Esse, from the Creator God, "If you trust in my voice and you follow my commands, life will increase in you." For many, many years, Abraham waited because he and his wife, getting older and older, had no children. Then, finally, at the age wonderfully of 99, we're told that Sarah has this son, Isaac. So Isaac, Isaac, whom he loved, the child of his

old age. But more than that, the child of the promise, the child through whom he became the Father of many Nations, that Isaac, whom he loved with all his heart.

- 2.67** Now, here's Chapter 22. "After these things, God tested Abraham. He said to him, 'Abraham!' And he said, 'Here I am.' He said, 'Take your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains that I shall show you.'" Now, again, Kierkegaard, I quoted earlier, writes a book called *Fear and Trembling* that's based on this passage. The title gives it away, doesn't it? If you read this story and you're not seized with fear and trembling, you have not properly understood it. Again, listen to what God says, "Take your son, your only son, Isaac"—he names him—"whom you love,"—just in case you've forgotten—"and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there on the mountain."
- 2.68** It's heartbreaking in every way, isn't it? How could God be this cruel? How could God be this capricious? And also, theologically, how weird that the God who said, "Through this son, you'll become the father of many nations. I'd like you to sacrifice him to me." It's as though God is at war with himself. As we enter the story, we enter onto very weird, dangerous, strange, upsetting ground. So, Abraham obeys. He's our father in faith. He follows the voice. He sets out with his son, and they come to the place of sacrifice, and Isaac carries the wood of sacrifice up the hillside.
- 2.69** And then, it's one of the most heartbreaking scenes in the whole Bible when the son says to his father, "We have the means of the sacrifice, but where's the animal for the sacrifice?" Imagine the heartbreak Abraham is feeling at this point. He says to him simply, "God will provide." Then, the dreadful moment when Abraham, obeying the voice, obeying *Ipsum Esse*, raises the knife, and only then is the hand stayed by the angel. And the Lord says, "Now I know of your faith." And you say, oh, gosh. I guess I see his faith, but did he have to go through this awful ordeal?
- 2.70** We're actually—and Kierkegaard saw this, the fear and trembling. He also saw that we're on very sacred ground here with this text. Now, why? Why? Because it hinges on a distinction central to the spiritual order. Do we love God, or do we love the benefits of God? Let me say it again. Do we love God?—remember, love means to will the good of the other—do we love God, or do we love the benefits of God?
- 2.71** God gives us all kinds of benefits. That's true. Whatever I have is a gift from God. And I say, "God has given me health and life and family and friends and success." What do I love, actually? Press it. What am I worshiping, actually? What's the *summum bonum*, actually? Am I worshiping God, or am I worshiping the benefits God has given me?
- 2.72** If it's the latter, then I'm not really worshiping God. If I love the benefits, I'm not really loving God. I'm loving myself. Now, hard truth, yes, and we're all sinners here, and so we all know what that's like. "Oh, no, look, I'm a bishop of the church. Of course, I love God." Really? Really? Or do you love the benefits that God has given you? Hard

question. Don't read this so much psychologically. Read it spiritually. The Bible does it all the time, by the way. It compels its heroes to come to grips with that question.

- 2.73** Can I give you another example? The famous Book of Job. Satan has been patrolling the Earth, saying, "There's so much wickedness. No one's following you, God." And God says, "Oh, no, oh, no. Do you notice my servant Job? He follows me. He's really righteous." And he is righteous. Satan goes, "Well, yeah, sure. You've given him every benefit." We know that Job's got family and wealth, and pleasure, and power, and fame, anything you want. He's got it. So, God says, "Okay. All right, Satan, go. Take all that from him." And he does. That dreadful opening of the Book of Job. In one fell swoop, all that stuff is taken away, and Job is still faithful.
- 2.74** And then, Satan says, "Yeah, but you haven't let me touch his person. If I make him sick, that will turn him against you." So, God says, "Okay, do it." And then, Job is covered in boils. It's the same image. It's the same image. The question Job, is, "Do you love God, or do you love the benefits of God?"
- 2.75** The Bible proposes these tests to us. They're meant as a spiritual boot camp that we put ourselves through this experience. Here's one from the New Testament: "Lord, I'll follow you, but first, let me bury my father." You think if there's ever been a good excuse, that's one. "Look, I'm with you. I'll follow you, but can I please, first, for a couple of days, bury my father?" What does the Lord say? "Let the dead bury their dead." And you say, "Isn't he being a little difficult?" No, it's making the same spiritual point. It's making the same spiritual point.
- 2.76** Do you love the benefits of God, or do you love God, the will of God for its own sake? It's Abraham's clarity on that point that makes him the father of faith. See what I'm driving at? It makes him the definitive model of faith in the Bible. That's why it's such an important move. It's going to be echoed now up and down the Bible.
- 2.77** And let me close with this: it's going find its purest expression, where? On this figure, maybe around 30 years old, a young rabbi nailed to an instrument of torture. The Romans had perfected the art of crucifixion. It was one of the most dreadful ways to die. Stripped, literally, of his clothes, stripped of any honor. They're spitting at him and calling him names as he dies. Stripped of his friends. They all abandon him. Wealth, pleasure, power, honor—he doesn't have one bit of it. And yet, in that moment, he remains aligned to the will of his father.
- 2.78** Do you love God, or do you love the benefits of God? Upon the answer to that question, your faith really turns. The right ordering of your life turns. Whether you're a rose window or you've disintegrated, whether you're a symphony or cacophony, depends upon how we adjudicate this question of right praise.

Lecture 3: Law and True Freedom

At a glance — Law and true freedom.

- 3.1 The purpose of the first two lectures really was to set a framework for the Bible. One of the biggest problems people have, I think, is losing the forest for the trees. You pick up the Bible, you have all these strange stories and odd names, and things just get confusing very quickly without an interpretive framework.
- 3.2 To review: God's name is I am who I am. God is not one of the things in the world, not one being among many, but that source of existence itself, that which can be neither grasped nor hidden from, the one who's luring us into a relationship of love, not avoidance or manipulation, but love, the God who makes the entire universe out of sheer love. Why do we know that? Because God has no need of the world. Therefore, he can utterly love the world for its own sake.
- 3.3 He creates the world, and Genesis lays it out in that beautiful poetry as a liturgical procession because all these elements should not be worshiped as gods, but they should be part of a great chorus of praise to the one God. Who comes at the end of the procession but human beings, those who lead the chorus of praise. So, we see, there is the basic framework. Right ordering comes from worthshipping, worshiping the true God. God is the summum bonum, not anything else. When we do that, our souls become like rose windows. They become like these beautifully integrated holes. Then, we tend to radiate around us order and harmony. That's the basic framework.
- 3.4 I think what the Bible does is it rings the changes on these themes over and over again. It shows us what goes wrong with us when we fall out of right relationship with God and what it looks like when we're in this attitude of right praise or right worship. I think when you've got that framework in place, you can fit a lot of these stories in. So, what I'm going to do next two lectures is roam around within the Old Testament and show how the Bible is bringing these changes.
- 3.5 Maybe one last little reminder: the centrality of that story of the Akedah, that terrible story where Abraham is called upon to sacrifice his son. What's the point again? Do we love God for his own sake, or do we love the benefits of God? We have to come to grips with that because if we're loving the benefits of God, we're still loving creatures rather than the creator. And so, the great test, don't psychologize that scene so much but theologize it. It's about clarifying the manner of our praise. With all that in mind, let's start moving through some of these great stories, which have shaped all of Western civilization.
- 3.6 The first one I'm going to look at is from the Book of Exodus. We'll go back. We saw Moses, the burning bush, and receiving the holy name. But what mission is he given? And by the way, nobody in the Bible, there's no exception, ever receives an experience of God without being sent on a mission. That's a basic biblical intuition. When you

receive the grace, now you've got to give it away. You've experienced God. You don't just rest in that. No, you go forth on a mission.

- 3.7** So, what's the mission Moses is given? It's a mission of liberation. "Let my people go. Liberate my people." I think it's fair to say there is no liberation movement anywhere, at least in Western culture, political liberation movement, cultural liberation movement, that's not been influenced by this great story. It's the [inaudible] story of freedom. Now, there's a political dimension to it, to be sure, but what I want to focus on is the spiritual dimension.
- 3.8** The right relationship to God gives rise to spiritual freedom. Bad praise and falling out of right relation to God leads to enslavement. I want to lay that out because it's such a basic principle in the entire Bible. When I start worshiping something less than God—it's wealth, it's power, it's pleasure, it's honor, it's my country, it's my family, whatever it is. Mind you, all those things are good in themselves, but when they become the object of my worship, they become my summum bonum, my highest good, what happens is I become their slave. Why? Because we've been made for God. "Lord, you've made us for yourself and therefore our heart is restless till it rests in thee." Saint Augustine's great line, but that's deeply biblical.
- 3.9** We've been made for God. We have an infinite longing that only the infinite God can satisfy. When I try, therefore, to put something finite in my soul to satisfy that longing, it's never going to work, is it? So, I make wealth my summum bonum, my highest good, and I strive after wealth, and I get some wealth. And it does give me a buzz. It gives me a thrill. I made my first, whatever your goal was, your first million dollars. But then that buzz wears off. It has to because we're not built for that. We're built for God. So then, I have to strive and strive and strive to make my second million. I get that. I get the buzz, but it's not as long-lasting as the first one. Now, I'm caught in this addictive pattern. I need more and more and more of it.
- 3.10** Now, fill in the blank. Maybe it's not wealth. Maybe it's pleasure. Pleasure is your poison. You seek pleasure, and you get it, and you get a buzz from that. But it wears off, and now you need more and more and more of it. Before you know it, whenever you make something less than God into God, you become an addict, and you become enslaved to that false God.
- 3.11** Welcome now to this story. It's a story of liberation. "Moses, now that you've experienced the true God, now that you know the true God's name, I want you to go to liberate my people." Now, let me give you a framework here. I mentioned Origen of Alexandria in the last lecture. For my money—I'll go out on a limb here—for my money, the single greatest commentator on the Bible in the whole tradition, a second- into the third-century figure from Alexandria in Egypt. Origen sets the tone for so much biblical commentary over the centuries. Let me give you his reading of this Exodus story.

- 3.12** Whenever I do this, I always have the Ten Commandments movie in my mind for some reason. Joel Brenner is the Pharaoh, and Charles Heston is Moses. Origen says to think of the Israelites now, the enslaved Israelites, as standing for all that's good and beautiful and creative within you. They stand for your mind, and for your will, and for your energies, and your creativity. The Egyptians—the king (Pharaoh) and the Egyptians are the oppressors. They stand for this addiction, which is holding captive everything that is beautiful and good in you. All your positive qualities are enslaved to this addiction.
- 3.13** Now, look in the story. When the Egyptians enslave the Hebrews, they make them do a couple of things. They make them build fortifications and then monuments to Pharaoh. Think about something. How much time do we, sinners, spend in our day using our minds, our wills, our creativity, all that's good in us, to build basically fortifications around ourselves and monuments to ourselves? Our own egotism, our own addiction, is like Pharaoh that's now commandeering all that's good and right in us.
- 3.14** There's a warfare inside, Origen says, a battle between oppressor and oppressed. Where does it come from? Bad praise, bad worship. Something has become the summum bonum that should not be the summum bonum. And so, the result is: the best of me is held captive to the worst of me. What's the message? "Let my people go. Let my people go" Liberate your powers and your creativity and your mind and your will to follow what God wants.
- 3.15** So, Moses goes back to Pharaoh and says, "Let my people go." And what's the reaction? "Oh, sure. No problem. I'll get right on it." Of course not. Pharaoh resists, in fact, makes their work more difficult. "I want the same quota of bricks," but they're not getting straw." They got to go find the straw for themselves. Look, fellow sinners, we all know this. When we try to find liberation from the addiction that has a hold on us, is it easy? No, no. Because the old self, organized in a particular way, battles against this call to liberation. It resists it. This is where I think of Joel Brenner as the Pharaoh, standing there, resisting any attempt by God to bring us to liberation.
- 3.16** Don't be surprised when you meet that resistance inside of you. What does Moses do now? He threatens Pharaoh with the plagues. And then, one by one, the 10 plagues come: the frogs and the snakes, the river turning to blood, culminating in the killing of the eldest son, even of Pharaoh. And you say, "It's God being a tough guy and putting Pharaoh in his place." No, read the Egyptologist in light of this. Go through the 10 plagues. What you see are elements within creation, which the Egyptians, at one time or another, deified. Whether they're these animals, the snakes, the Nile River itself, or Pharaoh himself, all of these are worshiped. What do you see there but the undoing of Genesis?
- 3.17** Genesis sees all these things coming forth from God, even those that creep and crawl on the Earth like gnats and so on and mosquitoes. They all come forth from God. They're all good, but they're not God. They're not God. They should be part of the

course of praise to God. What's the fundamental problem with Egypt? It's not just political oppression. It's bad praise. It's bad praise. And so, what God is doing is not just threatening Egypt; he's one by one dethroning the false gods.

3.18 Here's a line now that is very prominent in this story, but everyone seems to overlook it. We all know, "Let my people go." That line is echoed, as I say, up and down the centuries. "Let my people go." But what's the second part of that? "That they might worship me in the desert." "Let my people go, Pharaoh, that they might worship me." This is so basic, everyone, in the Bible, that liberty, true liberty, is related to right praise. The plagues are trying to undo the false forms of praise, which have led to the enslavement of the Israelites. It's false praise in you and in me that leaves the best of us to be enslaved to our addiction. "Let my people go that they might worship me" and thereby recover the Garden of Eden. "Let them go that they might worship."

3.19 When Israel finally is liberated from Egypt, the Egyptians are happy to see them go. And in fact, they give them what they call the spoils of Egypt; they are given to the Israelites. It's a very interesting point. It's not just, "Hey, we're tougher than you are, and we won this battle." It's, "Those who know how to praise God right know how to use the goods of the world."

3.20 So, think of the spoils of the Egyptians, all their wealth, and all the prerogatives of their lives— if you're worshiping the wrong way, you don't know how to use those things. Those things, in fact, will turn on you. Those who know how properly to worship should be handed these goods. It's that wonderful reversal. God is not telling us, "Don't use the goods of the world," but worship has to come first. Then, you'll know what to do with the goods of the world.

3.21 Israel now escapes from Egypt. "Let my people go." "Yes, go." But is Pharaoh satisfied? Oh, no, no. He very quickly turns around and comes after them. Again, fellow sinners, all of us who wrestle to find true conversion. Is it easy? Uh-uh. Mustering the energy, mustering the focus to do it, and then we think, "Yes, I'm on the right road. Yes, I'm going toward right praise." But the old self doesn't let go easily, does it? The old self keeps fighting back. So, Pharaoh comes after them.

3.22 Israel finds itself famously between the rock and the hard place: pharaoh behind them and the Red Sea in front of them. What's the Red Sea? Remember I mentioned the other day, the *tohu wa-bohu*? The primal chaos asserting itself in the flood of Noah. Jesus walks on the stormy water. It stands for all that is opposed to God's creative intention for us. So, there's Israel between Pharaoh advancing and between the *tohu wa-bohu* of the Red Sea.

3.23 How many of us, sinners and addicts—because every sinner is an addict— how many of us reach that point and we say, "Okay, I give up. Okay, I'll go back. The new life is too hard for me. I'll go back to the way it was." This motif you see all over popular culture. A really good example are the Matrix movies. Matrix movies are very spiritually alert.

So, they've escaped from a false world, the world of false consciousness, and they move into the new real world. Is it pleasant? Anything but. It's a terrible, unpleasant world. So it is as we're making the transition from the old life of bad worship to the true worship.

- 3.24** So there, Moses and Israel are stuck. There, we often feel stuck. What does he do, though? With confidence in God, he strikes the water. That's the move, everybody. That's the move. You don't go back. Don't go back to the way it was. But with confidence in God, we strike the very thing that seems the obstacle to us, and we will find a path opens up. Again and again, we find this in the mystics and the spiritual masters. There's a lovely line, "Where you stumble, that's where you dig for treasure." It's at those hardest points that we feel completely blocked. That's when you strike with confidence in God, and you'll find a path opening up. That's the parting of the Red Sea, allowing Israel to move closer to the promised land.
- 3.25** Now, they make their way through the Red Sea. And where is Moses leading them? Oh, into the land of 'let me do whatever I want.' No. Where is he leading them? To Mount Sinai, The Mountain of God. Now, mountains in the Bible. We go up where God comes down. Mountains are meeting places. Here's something interesting. In the Garden of Eden, it says that four rivers flowed forth from it. If that's true, it must have been something like a height, and the river is flowing forth from it. So, the Garden of Eden is a mountain. Think of Mount Ararat, where the Ark comes to rest. The Ark is a floating temple. Think of even Jacob's ladder, which is not like a ladder with rungs. It's more like a ziggurat, more like a temple. It's a mountain.
- 3.26** So, Moses is leading the people toward the mountain of the Lord, where they will encounter him, and there they receive the law. This is a theme that's so basic in the Bible, but it's so easy for us to slide past it. True liberty, "Let my people go," true liberty, is related directly to the law, related directly to obedience to the law. How does that make any sense?
- 3.27** Let me propose a comparison to you. I got this from Servais Pinckaeris, who's—he died a few years ago—one of the best moral theologians in the Catholic Church after the Vatican Council. Pinckaeris distinguishes between what he calls freedom of indifference and freedom for excellence. Freedom of indifference, freedom for excellence. Now, what's the distinction? Freedom of indifference is typical of the modern period. I'm free in the measure that I hover above the yes and the no. I'm indifferent to yes or no. And then, on the basis of no internal or external coercion, I make my choice. I decide, yes or no, A or B. That's the freedom of indifference. Freedom as a choice, if you want.
- 3.28** On that reading, what's the law? The law is a necessary evil, maybe. I get it. We have to have laws, like traffic laws, so we don't kill each other. There got to be certain limitations to our freedom. But deep down, I don't like the law because I'd like to be totally free. I want to be able to make any decision I want. I'd like to be able to drive my car at 120 miles an hour. I'd love a world with no stop signs. Let me do whatever I want.

For the freedom of indifference, the law is a problem, at best, a necessary evil. The freedom of indifference person says, "I don't get it. They just got liberated from Egypt, and they're going where? To a mountain to talk to God and receive a law, which is going to oppress them even more?"

- 3.29** But now, look at the second type of freedom that Pinckaeris calls freedom for excellence. What's that? It's the disciplining of desire so as to make the achievement of the good first possible and then effortless. Let me say that again. I'll give you an example of that. The freedom for excellence is the disciplining of desire so as to make the achievement of the good first possible and then effortless.
- 3.30** So, I'm standing before you as a relatively free speaker of English. I can say pretty much whatever I want to say. I've been studying foreign languages most of my life, and I'm not that good at any of them. And what I always felt when I was first starting my studies, when I was over in France and studying French, was unfree. I'd be in a seminar, and I knew what I wanted to say, and I'm struggling to say because I can't find the words. I haven't internalized French to that degree. Or when I was doing my pastoral work in California, and I wanted to preach a sermon in Spanish, and I knew exactly what I wanted to say, but I kept coming up with the wrong word, or I'd get blocked.
- 3.31** The point is that you become free to speak a language, not in the measure that you ignore the law, but in the measure that you internalize the law. Does that make sense? The syntax and the grammar and the vocabulary and all that of English, I took in from the time I was a kid, and my parents corrected me all the time, and teachers corrected me, and I began to read, and I internalized that law so that now I can effortlessly, as I stumble over the word, as I effortlessly speak English.
- 3.32** Or look at anyone that plays a musical instrument. I play the guitar poorly, but it's the same thing. When you first start and hear that song. I've always wanted to play that song, but I can't. I don't know all those cords. I don't know all those patterns. But then, as you play it and start internalizing the rules of music and of this particular instrument, you get it in your body, how to form your fingers on the fretboard and all that, now you can start playing more freely. And if you're really good, you've really internalized the law; you can play anything you want on that instrument.
- 3.33** I'll give you one more example because it was something I vividly experienced. Like most amateur golfers, I'm a bad golfer, but I've been trying to golf for many, many years. And I was horrible at it until this friend of mine came along who was a—when he was a younger guy, he was a semi-pro golfer. So, really good. He sat down with me and said, "Show me your swing." I did, and he gave me this funny look. "Let's start with a few basics." And then, he got me properly aligned. My alignment was all off, and he got my grip right and put my shoulders in the right position. I stood there, and he said, "Now you're in the right address position." And I said, "I feel like Frankenstein. I feel like I can barely move." He goes, "I know you've been swinging the club so poorly for so long, but trust me, you're in the right position."

- 3.34** And then, he started giving me some laws of the golf swing. One was that a lot of bad golfers sway off of the ball, and you have to stabilize your leg. So, you turn around the ball. So, he puts two golf balls under my shoe and says, "It's going to stabilize your leg." And then, he told me, "You don't have enough shoulder turn." So, he said, "Pretend you're a waiter and you're holding glasses on a tray. Now turn and give them to me." And so, I turned, and he said, "No, I don't have them yet." And then, finally, when I turned sufficiently, he goes, "Now you got it."
- 3.35** He said, now you've got a good address position, and you're now ready to hit the ball. Well, I hit the ball with those few simple things that were correcting years of poor golf. He got me to hit the ball, not like Tiger Woods, but much better than I wanted. And then, he said to me, "That's enough for today." And I said, "No, no, no, give me more." I was excited about the law of golf because those laws, the few ones he gave me that one day, were making me a freer player. I knew right away there was so much more I could do on the golf course. I'm not a slave of my own bad golf.
- 3.36** That's the freedom for excellence, not the freedom of indifference, which is, "Hey, give me that golf club. Let me swing any way I want." Well, good luck with that program. You'll be the worst golfer in the Western world. Rather, no, "Keep giving me laws that I can internalize more and more so as to make myself free."
- 3.37** Now, put all this in the moral and spiritual framework. "Let my people go. I know they're addicted. I know they're messed up with bad praise. That's what caused all this enslavement. Let my people go that they might worship me in the desert. That they might go to Mount Sinai to go up toward the Lord and to receive as a gift, receive as a gift, the law. That they might then internalize it to such a degree that they can now effortlessly live in relation to God." Does that make sense? That, I think, opens up volumes within the Bible when we see the great love for the law.
- 3.38** My experience with my golf teacher reminded me of the Psalmist: "Lord, how I love your law, how I meditate upon it day and night." If you're a freedom of indifference guy, if your life is all about doing what you want, can you imagine meditating on the law? It's like, "I'm going to read the tax law? Isn't that wonderful? And the latest traffic restrictions, aren't they great?" No, you resent the law. But once you get this principle, "Lord, how I love your law, how I meditate upon it day and night" because I want to internalize it so that I might become free.
- 3.39** In some ways, it's the master idea of Israel. What do the prophets do all the time to bring people back to the law? The Psalmists and the wisdom writers are celebrating the beauty of the law. What is the king supposed to do? Help people live according to the law. Because they're oppressive? Mm-mm. Because they want the people to be free.
- 3.40** Now, a last stop here. Even after all of this, this beautiful exodus, and the passing through the Red Sea, and coming to Mount Sinai, receiving the law, are the people happy? No. We're longing for the fleshpots of Egypt. "Oh, remember in Egypt, how

great it was? Remember we sat by the fire and we ate whatever we wanted? I know we were slaves, but heck, it was a better life than we got now." The Bible is extraordinarily clear-eyed about that, about the resistance inside to real liberation. That even when we receive the divine law, It's like, let's do the golfing again. If I received this clarification but I'm finding it too difficult to follow these, let me go back to my old swing. At least I knew what I was doing. "I know, but you were the worst golfer in the country." "Yeah, but at least I knew how to play."

- 3.41** This is the constant temptation to return to the fleshpots of Egypt. And the biblical message is, "No, no, keep going. Keep going." They're not in the promised land yet. They're going through these various steps. The journey is toward the promised land of freedom and law at the same time. To get that is to get a lot of the Bible.
- 3.42** So, with that in mind, I want to turn to a second scene. It's the Israelites making their way toward the promised land, and they come up against external forces. So, they'd beaten Pharaoh. They got past Pharaoh in the Red Sea, but now they come up against the Amalekites. The Amalekites are mentioned a lot in the Old Testament. They come up at various places. The Israelite army engages Amalek, and they're fighting away. But we hear that up on the hillside, again, up on the mountain, is Moses, and he has his arms raised, invoking the Lord. As long as he's praying and his arms are raised, the battle goes well for Israel. But then, his arms get tired, and the arms go down, and the battle goes poorly for Israel.
- 3.43** So, along come these two figures, Aaron and Hur, and they hold up the arms of Moses so that he can keep praying, and the battle goes on. And it says that Israel mowed down Amalek with the edge of the sword. But then, there's this little line that we should meditate upon. It says, "Israel will battle Amalek down through the ages." So, that's an interpretive key. This is not just a story about a battle between Israel and some long-forgotten ancient Middle Eastern tribe. Amalek stands here, as do the Philistines, as do the Syrians, as do the Babylonians, as do the Greeks, as do the Romans, as do the Egyptians, for what's standing athwart God's creative purposes.
- 3.44** When you start walking the path of liberation, spiritually speaking, is everyone throwing flowers at you? Some are. Some are, but a lot of people, because they're on the path of sin and addiction, they don't like it. They don't like you being on the road to the promised land, so they will try to block you. Am I right? We all experience this. So, Amalek stands for all the forces that are going to be opposed to your walking toward the promised land.
- 3.45** How does Israel win? This is a very important thing to notice. They win through right praise. It's Moses praying that makes the battle go well. Notice how beautiful. Moses, indeed, is the one who's praying, but he's supported by others within the community. So, some are involved in the direct engagement with the forces of evil. Some are praying. They're doing it directly. Others are supporting those who pray. Think of the way the church is structured. That we have people within the church whose full-time

job is to pray, but they can't do that unless they have financial supporters and otherwise who allow them to live that life. Then, there are people who are engaged in the active struggle.

- 3.46** The point, again, is that the key here is not fighting fire with fire, not meeting worldly violence with more worldly violence. Rather, it's meeting false praise with true praise. That's always the key. When you start digging behind the biblical stories—if you read them superficially, you say, "Oh, that's ancient warfare." But dig down deep, and you'll find the real struggle is false worship against true worship.
- 3.47** Let me give you another example of battling Amalek down through the ages. Go a little bit forward now in Israelite history. We come to the era of King Saul. The Prophet Samuel is their supporting soul. Saul does battle with the Amalekites, we hear. There they are again. He's given the command by God to put the ban on them. And this is a very controversial thing. The ban meant, "Kill every man, every woman, every child, every animal in the enemy force." So, that's the command from God. So, King Saul does engage Amalek. He wins the battle. He kills the soldiers, he kills almost everybody, but he leaves the king, his name is Agag, and then some of the animals that he's going to use for his purposes. He leaves them alive.
- 3.48** So, along comes the Prophet Samuel, and he said, "What's going on here? Why is this king still alive? Why are these animals still alive?" And Saul has an excuse. Samuel's got none of it. That's where he dismisses Saul as king. And there's this little line: he takes out a sword, the Prophet Samuel, and it says, "He hacked Agag to pieces." This is read sometimes as a liturgy, and people will read that and say, "This is the word of the Lord. Thanks be to God."
- 3.49** Now, I know. If we stay simply at the superficial level of the narrative, you say, "What the heck? What is going on here?" But read it now the way Origen would read it. I'm just following Origen's prompts here. Amalek stands for the power of false worship, which will always stand athwart the true worship of Israel. They stand for those forces that will be in your way as you're moving toward the promised land. They stand for the fleshpots of Egypt. They stand for the 'let's go back the other way.' They stand for unfreedom, if you want. So, what's the watchword? The watchword is you have to resist these forces all the way down.
- 3.50** What solves the problem is he has a halfway battle with Amalek. Yeah, he basically got it covered, but he's left a little bit for himself. Again, fellow sinners, fellow addicts, do we play this game all the time? "Oh, yeah. No, I've turned a new leaf. Oh, no. I'm leading my life in a whole fresh way, but I've kept some of my bad habits. I've kept some of my sinful ways. Oh, it shouldn't cause any problem. Don't get me wrong. I'm totally with you, Lord. I'm totally with the program. I'm just keeping a few of these sinful tendencies." The Bible has no time for that.

- 3.51** Think of these analogies. If the doctor said to you, "That's great. I got great news for you. We got 90% of that cancer." Would you be happy? No, no. You'd like the doctor to hack the cancer to pieces. You don't want them leaving 10% of it. Or if one of my priests came to me and said, "Bishop, I love being a priest. It's a great life. And celibacy, I'm really good with it. I'm celibate, I'd say 90% of the time." Would I be happy with that? "Hey, I'm doing great. I just a little bit—" No. There are certain forms of dysfunction. A husband saying to his wife, "I love you, honey. You're the best. Which is why I'm faithful to you 95% of the time." Of course not.
- 3.52** There are certain forms of evil that have to be eradicated. They have to be battled all the way down. "You got to hack Agag to pieces." If we read it just as an account from the ancient world, what a brutal person. No, read it spiritually. A lot of our trouble comes because we don't hack Agag to pieces. We leave him around. What Agag is going to do, trust me, is going to raise a new army. You leave something in you that's still addicted to wealth or pleasure or power or honor. You leave certain sinful habits in you—that's going to raise an army eventually that's going to come after you. Don't deceive yourself. You got to hack them to pieces.
- 3.53** Let me give you a little hint for lectures to come. Where do we see this now as Christians? What does Jesus do on the cross? He battles evil all the way down. Couldn't he have just come, preached the good news, and then lived a long, happy life and died in his bed? What is the cross? The horror of the cross? What's he doing? He's going all the way down to the bottom of our dysfunction. He's fighting it all the way down. On the cross, he hacked Agag to pieces. I'll get there, but you see it anticipated in these stories of the ban, it seems to me. You can't play around with evil.
- 3.54** The great spiritual writer Thomas Merton, from the last century, Trappist monk, writes a lovely little piece called Firewatch. The fire watch was a practice in his monastery. He was a Trappist monk. One of the monks would be called upon each night with a flashlight and sneakers so he wouldn't wake up his brothers to go all over the monastery, looking for any trouble. Is there a fire breaking out or anything? And with the flashlight, he'd have to do a very, very careful inventory of the whole monastery. So, Merton takes that as a starting point but reflects upon it spiritually.
- 3.55** What's he doing as he goes through the library of the monastery? He goes to the kitchen, he goes down to the deep basement, he goes up to the top of the tower. He sees it as a metaphor for the searching moral inventory that we have to do. The library is like my mind. The kitchen is like my appetites. The tower is like my spiritual aspirations. The basement is like my animal energies. He's going with the flashlight, and he's looking all through the monastery. Because what? "Hey, the monastery is doing great. Just a little short circuit over here. Oh, yeah, that wire is a little bit frayed over there." Yeah, but that's going to be trouble. You can't leave that alone. You can't think that's not going to—

- 3.56** Do we do a searching moral inventory on our road to the promised land so that we don't let Agag in us raise another army? Because he will. So, the Prophet Samuel is right. "Saul, you're messing around with evil. You're not dealing with it." I think that's the message there.
- 3.57** Let me do one more story in this lecture. It's one that's maybe not as well known, but it's super illuminating, actually. The story of Eli and his wicked sons Hophni and Phineas. We're a little further along now in Israeli history. Who's Eli? Eli is a high priest. He's at the temple in Shiloh. Before the great Temple of Jerusalem was built, there was a temple in Shiloh. Eli is a high priest. He's an important figure. He has two sons, Hophni and Phineas. They're also priests at a lower level.
- 3.58** The words brought to Eli by the people that Hophni and Phineas are wicked, that they're abusing the people both sexually and monetarily. They're taking advantage of them both sexually, and they're stealing from them. Eli says, "I'll talk to them." And he does. He does. Eli says to his two sons, "Look, you got to cut this out. This is wrong." But they don't cut it out. They continue abusing the people. People come again and complain. Eli, "Yeah, I'll talk to them." But nothing happens. And then, disaster befalls Israel. They're in a battle with the Philistines. They bring the Ark of the Covenant into battle with them, hoping that God's presence would bring them victory. But instead, 30,000 are killed. The Ark is taken. Israel is humiliated. When the news is brought to Eli, he falls back, breaks his neck, and dies. And Hophni and Phineas were killed in battle.
- 3.59** And you say, "Isn't that a cheery story?" What's the point of it? Think about this. There's a high priest, there's a high leader in the church, to whom complaints are brought about abuse by priests. Nice words are said, "Oh, yeah, we'll take care of it." But then, nothing happens. More complaints are brought. More nice words are said, but nothing substantial happens. And then, disaster befalls the church. Does that sound familiar, any of that story? That's the last 25, 30 years in the Catholic Church, and I say it, honestly, to our shame.
- 3.60** Were there priests abusing people in different ways? Yeah, absolutely. Were complaints brought directly to church leaders? Yeah. Nice words said, usually. Action taken? Certainly not sufficiently. More complaints brought? Mm-hm. Action taken? Not really. And then, what happened? Disaster. I think of the church—most of my years in the priesthood, have been under the dark cloud of the sex abuse scandals. The church has suffered enormously, not just financially but in terms of reputation, in terms of our capacity to do our work.
- 3.61** Sometimes, the resistance to the promised land comes from outside. Think of Amalek. Sometimes, it comes from the old life we used to live. Think of Pharaoh coming after Israel. But sometimes, fellow sinners, we all know this: the trouble comes from inside of us. The trouble comes from within the redeemed community. And it's interesting that in the New Testament, in Mark's Gospel, the first demon that Jesus confronts, where does he find him? In the synagogue. Where's the first demon hanging out? In

church, in church. So, it's often, sad to say, but often in the places that are meant to be the havens of righteousness, the conduit to the promised land, that's where the corruption sets in.

- 3.62** We shouldn't be surprised. I've told people now to go back to that story from the ancient, ancient world. It tells almost exactly what's happening to us. You say, "I guess that's just a disaster." No, in the Bible, God never gives up on his people. It's his basic theme. He never gives up on his people. There's always a rescue operation coming. So, what's the rescue operation in this case?
- 3.63** It comes through Hannah. Hannah was an Israelite woman. She was one of two wives of this man, and she was childless. At the time, to be a childless woman was to be at the very bottom of the social ladder. It was to be a person that had no respect. And Hannah knows this. She feels it. She feels her own status in the society. And so year after year, she and her husband—and the other wife always mocks her, by the way, because she's childless, mocks her—they go up to Shiloh. That's where Eli is, as high priest. And she prays. She prays to God to give her a child.
- 3.64** At one time, she's praying, and she's moving her lips like this. And Eli sees her, Mr. Sensitivity, and says, "This woman's drunk." And he goes, "Why are you drinking in the middle of the day?" And she goes, "I'm not drunk. I'm pouring out my soul before the Lord." Eli needed a lot of remedial work and pastoral counseling. But he says, "The Lord has heard your prayer, and you will be given a child." So, she goes home and does become pregnant. She gives birth to Samuel, the so-called Shemu'el in Hebrew. It has the sense of having been begged, having been asked for.
- 3.65** Samuel is weaned, so he's still a very small child. But the moment he's weaned, we're told, Hannah takes him and returns him to Shiloh and gives him to Eli to raise in the temple as a priest. It's one of those typically odd biblical stories that gets our attention because it runs counter to much of our attitude, "Wait, I don't get it. She begged for this child. She begged, begged for years and years." And then, despite all opposition, she becomes pregnant. God gives her this child. Think Abraham, by the way, for a second here. God gives him Isaac, the child of the promise. God gives this child, Samuel. Wouldn't Hannah say, "Thank you, Lord, and my God, I'm going to hang on to this child for dear life." The opposite. She lets the child go and gives him back to God.
- 3.66** Now, I mentioned this yesterday. It's this idea of what I call the the loop of grace. When you receive the grace of God as a gift, you don't cling to it. Because gratia, grace, only exists in gift form. If you cling to it and make it your own, it's now my possession. You will lose it. It's like the most fundamental principle of biblical physics. If you cling to something in the spiritual order and try to make it your own, you will lose it. But if you take what's given to you and now you give it as a gift, it remains grace, and it will increase thirty, sixty, and a hundredfold.

- 3.67** "Unless the grain of wheat falls to the earth and dies, it remains just a grain of wheat. But if it dies, it produces much fruit." Same principle. The prodigal son, I mentioned, takes what the father gives him, hangs onto it, and loses it almost immediately. No, the idea is to receive it as a gift and now contrive a way to give it as a gift.
- 3.68** Israel was in a disaster because of Eli and his wicked sons. They lost the battle. They lost the Ark of the Covenant. They lost their way spiritually. What's the rescue operation? It's this lady, Hannah, at the lowest rung of the social ladder, this complete nobody. But it's through her and her willingness to give her son back as a gift, the son being Samuel, who will become a great prophet, who will anoint King David, who will eventually give rise to the new David. Without Hannah, there's no Christ. Without Hannah, there's no fulfillment of the promise. This is very typical of the way God tends to work.
- 3.69** Enter into the loop of grace. Don't hang on to what's given to you, and you will find it increasing thirty, sixty, and a hundredfold. The New Testament abounds with examples of this, but it came to my mind. Five thousand people. "Lord, they're all hungry. How can we possibly feed them? Let me send them away." "What do you have?" "Five loaves and a couple of fish, but what's that for so many people?" "Give them to me." And then, they're multiplied unto the feeding of the entire crowd. They're multiplied unto the feeding of the world. That's the principle, again. That's the principle. What you've received as a gift, give as a gift, and you'll find it increasing. That's how the story of Israel continues.
- 3.70** So, as we look at the further narratives, I want to keep an eye on that motif. We're journeying always toward the promised land. We're journeying toward liberation. But the condition for the possibility of liberation is worshiping God aright and learning how to enter into this loop of grace.

Lecture 4: Grace and Mission

At a glance — Grace and mission.

- 4.1 So, let's continue our romp through the Old Testament by turning to one of the most pivotal figures, namely King David. I say pivotal because David, in many ways, looks back toward Adam, who is construed as a kind of king, and looks forward to the son of David, Jesus, the king of Kings. David stands in the center there, pivoting back toward Adam, pivoting forward toward Christ. So, he's a figure that sheds light in all kinds of directions.
- 4.2 There are just three things I want to share about him, and they correspond to that old category of priest, prophet, and king because David is going to be all three of those. It's also worth noting that probably more than any other figure in the Old Testament, David is a fully realized character. We see the whole arc of his life, from the time he's a little kid till he's a very old man at the point of death. So, you get not really a full psychological portrait, but probably the richest portrayal of life of anyone in the Old Testament.
- 4.3 Here's the first thing I want you to see about David. He's "the sweet singer of the House of Israel." That's a lovely phrase from the King James Bible. That's their translation. "The sweet singer of the House of Israel." The first time we come across David, he's been called upon to play and to sing for King Saul, who's suffering from headaches. Today, we'd probably say from depression or anxiety. And so, they call upon this kid who can play the harp and sing. So, it's the lyrical side of life David represents.
- 4.4 Also, he gives that wonderful speech in the presence of Goliath and the Israelite army. He sings the eulogy to Jonathan and to Saul when they're killed. He's associated, too, with the Psalms. If you see an icon of David or a stained glass window, usually he's got the harp. So, he's a singer. He's someone that knows how to use words to move the heart.
- 4.5 Think of how many great political leaders led precisely through speech. I've been studying Lincoln since I was a kid. I got a Lincoln biography when I was about seven, and I've read, I don't know, 50 since then. Lincoln, maybe more than anybody in our history, is the sweet singer of the House of America. Does anyone evoke the American spirit more fully than Lincoln? I love the fact that when he was a kid, he tried to get his hands on books, but it was very difficult for him. But the two books he really knew were King James Bible and Shakespeare. That's not a bad way to shape your literary style. You see it reflected in all that lapidary prose of Lincoln.
- 4.6 Lincoln, at key moments—Gettysburg, most famously, the second inaugural, of course — became the sweet singer of the House of America. He expressed in lyrical language what we're about, and it gave the Civil War its purpose. It's the way he led. And then, of course, probably in the 20th century, most famously, Churchill, as they say, at that key

moment when England was flat on its back, he sent the English language into battle. And that's true, isn't it? In *The Darkest Hour*, the famous book and now movie, Churchill summoned his linguistic skill. He sang the meaning of England, and it turned the whole country round. It galvanized the nation.

- 4.7 FDR in our country in the 20th century—similar thing. During the Depression, in the time of the war, Roosevelt was able to articulate the meaning of it. How often leaders are able to do that? And religious leaders?
- 4.8 Think of the sweet singers in the course of Christian history, the great preachers and teachers and poets of Christianity. Martin Luther King is a prime example in the 20th century of a sweet singer of the Christian thing. And, of course, King, who was trained formally in theology, but especially as a Baptist preacher, knew his Bible and knew the manner of presenting it. When you watch King's speech, what strikes me is he's singing them. He's not really speaking them. I'm speaking this now. But whenever King—it was a song. That galvanized the civil rights movement. Of course, it did. The power of language.
- 4.9 Where are the sweet singers of the House of Christianity today? At a time when materialism is taking hold, the time of the new atheists, when there are a lot of singers of that position, singers of scientism and materialism and atheism, who's singing the Christian thing? Who's David today? One of our tasks as we do this work is precisely that: to express it in a lyrical way that people find compelling.
- 4.10 Do you know those lines? It's from one of the Psalms. As a priest, I pray the Psalms all the time. They're in what we call 'the office.' We have to pray every day. It's a Psalm from the time of the Babylonian captivity. It's an Israelite now in exile, and he says, "It was there that our captive asked us to sing one of Zion's songs. 'Sing to us,' they said, 'one of the songs of Zion.' But how could we sing the song of Zion on alien soil? And so, on the poplars that grew there, we hung up our harps." Now, that Psalm, I don't know, it's always sung to me with great sadness. It's people who—they're Israelites. They love the Lord, but they're in the land of exile, surrounded by enemies. The enemies ask them for a song, but they're not capable of singing it. They hung up their harps on the poplars.
- 4.11 This is a sense, everybody, I have very strongly. There are a lot of people today who are saying to us, to believers, "Sing to us one of Zion's songs. Sing to us these great biblical truths." But we feel we're like in exile. We're surrounded by enemies. So, how could we sing the songs of the Lord? Sadly, on the poplars that grew there, we've hung up our harps. My summons to a generation of younger Christians, younger people trained in the Bible, is to learn how to sing these texts again. To me, it's a very sad commentary that a lot of people don't even know the Bible anymore.
- 4.12 When you look at the politicians in our country, 19th century, certainly, well into the 20th century, you read their speeches, they could assume everybody knew this Book.

Everyone knew the great stories. You can't anymore. I've taught even at Catholic universities, and I'll make a reference to the Bible, and the kids have no idea what I'm talking about. At the same time, with all of this materialism, all of the atheism, and all of the nihilism and everything, and the young people experiencing it, it has been statistically shown again and again that young people are experiencing spiking numbers of anxiety and depression, suicidal tendencies.

4.13 I think what they're saying is, "Sing to us one of Zion's songs. Learn again how to sing this text." That, to me, is what David—it's one of the prime ways that he led, just as Lincoln, just as Churchill, just as King—one of the prime ways that he led was by singing, and so we need to do that, too. There's such an etiquette of our modern society toward the privatization of religion. "Keep it yourself. Don't impose your religion on people. No one wants that." Yeah, but the trouble with that is if we take it all the way, all we're doing is hanging up our harps on the poplars. We're hanging them up, and we no longer sing the songs of Zion. So, I think David comes to mind as a key player there. So, he's a singer.

4.14 The second thing is he's a warrior. Right from playing the harp for Saul, he goes out—he's a kid. How old is he? Thirteen or fourteen—to meet Goliath. And that famous scene that everybody knows. Goliath, the giant, how tall is he? People are guessing based on the figures given, like 6'7, 6'8. He's probably like LeBron or something. He's probably that size person, I always think. But I love how they describe his armor in exquisite detail: what his helmet is like and his sword, how big the spear is, and what he's wearing. They're using all this technical language. It'd be like someone today describing the tanks, the artillery, and the bombs.

4.15 So, Goliath comes out. He's a giant, and he's accoutered in all of the latest weapons of war. He stands for worldly power. That's the point. Look at the Israelites when they're in captivity, they're building fortified—they're building fortifications and monuments to their leaders. Goliath is like that. He's this worldly figure, and he challenges the Israelites. And of course, they're cowed into submission.

4.16 That's the world vis-à-vis the church in many ways today. And I'm speaking broadly here: the world against believers. We're getting cowed a lot as they come at us with all the worldly strength, and we go, "Oh, who are we?" Thank God, little David, "I'll take him on. I'll take him on." And then, it's beautiful when Saul says, "Let me give you my armor," but it's too big for him, and David can't even move. He says, "No, no, no, I won't use any of this."

4.17 I was in Florence a couple of years ago. We were filming over there, and I saw Michelangelo's David for the first time. The nudity of David is an interesting thing. Obviously, Michelangelo loved portraying the human form, but it's a spiritually important theme, actually, the nakedness of David, because it means he's going out to meet his opponent with none of the defenses of the world. He's going out to meet this great militarily accoutered giant but with nothing except his trust in the Lord. That's the

sweet singer again. He says, "You come after me with sword and scimitar, but I come after you with the power of the Lord God."

4.18 There are maybe some here old enough to remember—go back to the early, early years of John Paul II. He goes to Poland in 1979, and he speaks in Victory Square. It's the heart of Warsaw. This was the height of the Cold War. When I was a kid, the Soviet Union, with all these nuclear weapons, was the ultimate enemy. We were petrified of the Soviet Union. And John Paul II doesn't have one tank, doesn't have one gun. There's no army with him, nothing. But he stands up there in that Victory Square.

4.19 They say about a million people were there, and he just began speaking about God and about the human person and about human rights and about salvation and about dignity. He was a sweet singer of the House of Christianity. He was a sweet singer. And they say, the crowd, a million strong, began to chant, "We want God, we want God, we want God." The communist leadership was behind the Pope right there. It went on for 15 minutes, they say. In a way, at that moment, the Soviet Union collapsed. It started a process, which led, eventually, to the breakdown of this mighty Empire.

4.20 If you had told me when I was a kid that the Soviet Union would fall apart with barely a shot fired, and that a key player would be the Pope? Forget it. It would have been the wildest fantasy. But that's what happened because "you come after me with sword and scimitar, but I come after you with the power of the Lord God." That biblical idea is still resonant.

4.21 I mean, King knew it, too, didn't he? Martin Luther King coming against the powers of a fallen society.

4.22 But he didn't come after them with sword and cimitar. He came nonviolently, but with the power of the Lord God. Don't think these are just old, charming stories. There's power in these stories. So, David goes out and, of course, conquers Goliath with just a little slingshot. Notice, please, that he kills Goliath and cuts off his head. You better "hack Agag to pieces." Don't mess around. Don't mess around with evil. "You know what? Why don't we capture Goliath, and we'll bring him into our army?" No, no, no. You cut off his head. You got to fight wickedness all the way down. Don't mess around with it.

4.23 So, there's David, the warrior. How wonderful throughout the story of David, he's always ready for a fight. David's always ready to go on a campaign. Well, this is the church, if you want. It should always be willing to engage the powers. Now, again, as I've been arguing throughout these lectures, I'm not arguing for violence. I'm saying this is a metaphor for the church's engagement of a wicked world. The trouble is when we privatize our faith and quiet ourselves in the presence of wickedness. No, no, you're meant to go out. You're meant to go out to fight it.

4.24 David's always willing. Until when—let me read you something. I think I marked this one. From Goliath on, David is always ready to fight, always ready to go in until Chapter

11 . Listen. "In the spring of the year, the time when kings go out to battle"— and David, you're a king, you're always ready—"David sent Joab with his officers and all Israel with him. And they ravaged the Ammonites. But David remained at Jerusalem."

4.25 What's the matter with him? He's always ready for a fight. What's the matter with him? Listen. "And then it happened, late one afternoon, when David rose from his couch and was walking about the roof of the king's house. He saw from the roof a woman bathing. The woman was very beautiful. David sent someone to inquire about the woman." It was reported that "this is Bathsheba. She's the wife of Uriah, the Hittite, one of your most loyal soldiers. David sent messengers to get her, and she came to him, and he lay with her."

4.26 What are we noticing here? That time of year when kings go on campaign: David, you ready to go? No, no. He stays home and sends somebody else. And then, it says, "Late in the afternoon." These are Mediterranean people, so the siesta is a normal part of life, but the fact that it mentions late in the afternoon: this guy has been having a long siesta. He's getting fat and sassy here.

4.27 Then, he gets up, and instead of listening to God and doing what God wants, he begins acting like God. That's the parading around on the roof. "Let me see what I can see here. Oh, look at there. Isn't she beautiful? Send for her." "Oh, no, wait a minute. She's married. In fact, she's married to one of your most loyal officers." "I don't care. Send for her." It's a devastating account. Yes, David is the sweet singer of the house of Israel. Yes, he's the great warrior. He's the greatest king. But if you start playing around and you stop listening to God and start listening to your own manipulative ego and all of that, you're not worshiping God. You're acting like God. Then, the battle goes wrong. Then, everything is off-kilter.

4.28 It's a really good thing for us to think about. Have we stopped singing the truth of the faith ? And have we, that time of year when we're meant to go out and campaign, have we decided, "I'm going to stay home and have a long nap." It's an indictment , I think, of our unwillingness to get into the fight.

4.29 Here's the third thing I want you to see. So, he's a singer, and he's a warrior. And finally, he's a priest. He's a priest. How do we know that? Do you remember the Ark of the Covenant had been lost? It was that Eli battle when Hophni and Phineas go out, and the Philistines capture the Ark. They kept it for a long time, and it started doing mischief among the Philistines. So, they send it in an oxcart. They send it away, and it ends up at the house of an Israelite.

4.30 But David now has become king, and he says that if this kingdom is going to be righteous, at the heart of it has to be the Ark of the Covenant. And what does the Ark represent? Right praise. The liturgy. Right praise , worship of the true God, must be at the heart of my society, or it's not going to work . And so, David fetches the Ark, and

they arrange—go right back to Genesis. Remember the elements coming forth like a liturgical procession? They arrange a liturgical procession with the Ark in a cart.

- 4.31** And then, David—it's a little detail that we've missed, but they didn't miss it—is wearing what's called an ephod. And ephod was the tunic of a priest in the temple. So, he takes off his kingly garb and puts on a priest garb. And then it says, "With abandon, he danced before the Ark as it made its way into Jerusalem." Now, I submit to you that it's a beautiful scene that's worthy of our meditation. He's a singer. He's a fighter at his best, though we had a bad moment with Bathsheba. But here he's a priest. The priest is someone who is leading the people in right praise.
- 4.32** Go right back to the Book of Genesis. When we hear a reference to Adam walking with the Lord in the cool of the evening. It's a beautiful image. It means when our humanity is aligned to God. When you're walking with someone, and you're talking, you have to fall in step with that person. If you're walking too fast, you can't talk, or too slow—you've got to imitate their rhythm.
- 4.33** So, Adam walking with the Lord means my mind, my will, my passions, my body, all that is aligned unto God. That's the rose window, but now it's the rose window in motion. I'm moving with the Lord. I'm moving in rhythm and harmony with him. What's the dance of David but exactly that? It's David moving in rhythm with the Lord. So, David dancing in the presence of the Ark is David moving in rhythm and harmony with the Lord.
- 4.34** Here's a very interesting thing. Some scholars suggest that when the Temple is established—it'll be built by David's son, Solomon, but David is the inaugurator of it, and he brings the Ark into Jerusalem. When the Temple is built, liturgies now take place, and the priests there, garbed in liturgical vestments, will engage in certain gestures, movements, and so on, bows and processions. What was that meant to be but an imitation of David's dance?
- 4.35** This comes right up from the Temple into early Christian liturgical traditions. What do I do as a priest and a bishop? I put on vestments, I process, I walk around the altar, I use things like incense, I'll bow down, I'll raise my arms, and so on. What is that but a kind of dance? And the people respond in their own way. What we're doing as we sing together and pray together and gesture and move together, we're getting in line, getting in harmony with the Lord.
- 4.36** So, this is the third, and I would argue, the most important way that David leads. He sings, he fights, and then he praises. He's a priest, he's a prophet, and he's a king. Now, to anticipate our later lectures, who's Jesus? He's the son of David. You look at Matthew's Gospel, the genealogy, the list of generations preceding Jesus; there are three sets of 14 generations. In Hebrew, numbers and letters correspond to each other. For every letter is a number and vice versa. Fourteen is the number for David.

- 4.37 So, what's Matthew telling us? David, David, David has come, the new David. The sweet singer par excellence. Think of Jesus, the preacher. Jesus, the fighter, par excellence. Think of the naked Christ on the cross, going out against the powers of the world. Jesus, the high priest. We say on that cross, a sacrifice is made. I'm getting a bit ahead of myself, but there is David, priest, prophet, and king, anticipating the fulfillment that we'll find in Christ.
- 4.38 Maybe a word about the Temple. I've been alluding a few times to the Temple, but it's really worth thinking about. David inspires it. He assembles a lot of the material for it, but his son, Solomon, is actually going to build the Temple. The Temple on the top of Mount Zion— so again, the mountain. We go up; God comes down. It's a meeting place of heaven and earth. The Temple, they say, was constructed with elements that were meant to represent all the elements of the world. The colors used in the decoration of the Temple were meant to evoke all the elements within the cosmos. It's decorated inside and out with animals and plants and with planets.
- 4.39 Because, as human beings, we're meant to lead all of creation in a course of praise. As human beings came to the Temple to offer sacrifice, they weren't just praying on their own behalf. They were, as it were, channeling the praise of all of the cosmos toward God.
- 4.40 Jesus, again, at the climax of his life, will come into that Temple. "I'm going to tear this place down and in three days rebuild it," referring to the temple of his own body. Where does all come together? In Jesus, who's the true temple and the new David, priest, prophet, and king. So, all of that is being anticipated here. But I wanted you to see those three offices.
- 4.41 Now, the next story I want to tell you about is one of my favorites because it's strange, it's funny, it's very rich, spiritually. It has to do with the man whom the ancient Israelites would have seen as the supreme prophetic figure. Isaiah and Jeremiah are the great literary prophets; they write these great books. But the figure they would have known as the great prophet was Elijah.
- 4.42 Elijah emerges—now we're talking about the period after King David. Elijah emerges during the time of King Ahab. Ahab is described very blithely as worse than all of the kings of Israel combined. Knowing the kings of Israel, that's a really damning comment. Ahab is a really, really bad guy. Now, why? Why? Based on my lectures, by this point, I'm sure you could guess—because he's gone over to the worship of false gods. He's followed the gods of his wife, Jezebel, and the gods, the Baals, they call at this point. So, it's always the same rhythm. Bad worship leads to the dissolution of the individual and to the division of society, and that's why Ahab is a bad king.
- 4.43 So, we hear he comes completely out of the blue. This figure, Elijah, is called the Tishbite from Tishba. No one knows anything about it. We get no background in Elijah. He suddenly emerges in opposition to Ahab because in the wake of his bad worship,

what's happened? A drought has occurred. Now, we know, by now, that this is not accidental but spiritual physics. Bad praise leads you from the garden into the desert. It always has. Bad praise is the key to lifelessness. So, when the Israelites go over to the worship of the Baals, a drought occurs.

- 4.44 So, Elijah comes to challenge Ahab. "When Ahab saw Elijah, Ahab said to him, 'Is it you, you troubler of Israel?' He answered, 'I've not troubled Israel, but you have, and your father's house because you've forsaken the commandments of the Lord and followed the Baals.'" Really clear. Really clear. That's what prophets do. Prophets raise their voice in opposition to bad worship and bad government. Notice how this is not a man accepting the theory that we should privatize our religious convictions. No, no, he comes right in the face of the king, with the power of the Lord, and challenges him.
- 4.45 Then, he goes on. "Have all Israel assembled for me at Mount Carmel with the 450 prophets of Baal and the 400 prophets of Asherah who eat at Jezebel's table." He's calling them out for a mano a mano. "Look, I know there are 450 priests of Baal. There's one of me. There's one little Elijah. But I'm going to call them out. Let's go to Mount Carmel, and let's have a duel."
- 4.46 The first thing we should notice is—and this has always been true, and it's true today—the priests of the false gods are always thick on the ground. Am I right? The avatars of the false gods, there are a lot of them around all the time. Think of all the voices, summoning our young people to worship a false god. There are a lot of them. A lot of them. How many priests of the true God? Not that many. It's usually an uneven struggle in terms of numbers. That's why Saint Augustine saw the church through the centuries as little Noah's Ark, bobbing on the waves of this mighty *tohu wa-bohu* of the world.
- 4.47 Okay, so it goes, but Elijah doesn't care; it doesn't bother him. "Send these prophets out, and I'm going to take them on." Elijah said to the people, "I, even I only am left as a prophet the Lord, but Baal's prophet's number 450." So, it's like David and Goliath. He's just naming it. "I'm not afraid of it. I want you to know there's only one of me, and there's 450 of them." So, he then famously says, "Priest of Baal, you erect an altar to your gods, and I'll erect an altar to mine. We're both going to call on our respective deities, and we'll see who answers. You guys go first."
- 4.48 So, the priest of Baal erected the altar, and they pray, and they beg, and they cajole, and nothing happens. No fire falls. They then start getting desperate, and they're now dancing and leaping around their altars. Nothing happens. And then, we hear—it's a lovely detail—they take out knives, and they begin to slash themselves. So, the blood flows as a way of summoning their gods.
- 4.49 Now, listen to Elijah after all this is going on. "From morning to noon, they're crying, 'Oh, Baal, answer us!' But there was no voice, no answer. They limped about the altar that they had made." That's lovely, by the way, that they're limping around the altar.

But listen now. "At noon, Elijah mocked them, saying, 'Cry louder! Surely he's a god; either he's meditating, or he's wandered away, or he's on a journey, or perhaps he's asleep and must be awakened.' Then they cried it aloud, and, as was their custom, they cut themselves with swords and lances until the blood gushed out over them. As midday passed, they raved on until the time of the offering of the oblation, but there was no voice, no answer, no response."

4.50 By now, we should know the principles of play here. The question is always right praise. It's always right worship. We're meant for God. Only God can satisfy the deepest longing of the heart. When you align your desire to God, you will find satisfaction. The fire will fall. But when something less than God is turned into your ultimate good, your summum bonum, you can pray all you want. You can dance all you want. You can cut yourself with swords and bleed for these gods, but they won't answer.

4.51 You see how this, everybody, is not just some funny 'my God's bigger than your God' story from the ancient world? It's naming the dynamics of addiction. So again, as I mentioned earlier, if you're worshiping wealth and you've been dancing around that altar all your life, you've been dedicating yourself to that altar, you've gotten some satisfaction when you get your first million, but, of course, it wears off, as I said. Or you're hopping around the altar of power.

4.52 Do you ever know people for whom power is so addictive? That's all they want. They don't really care about money that much. They don't really care about honor that much. But by God, they want power, and they'll dance and hop and pray and cajole and even cut themselves in order to get power. And they might get along the way some satisfaction, but at the end of the day, the fire is not going to fall. Again, listen to that: "There was no voice, no answer, no response" because we're not meant for those things. They can't fill you up.

4.53 For some people, honor is their thing. I'm getting these, by the way, from Thomas Aquinas. He said the four great substitutes for God are wealth, pleasure, power, and honor. And I think that's really right. Most things that we seek are some version of those four things. Wealth, pleasure, power, and honor. Think of them maybe as four altars that we've erected to the Baals.

4.54 Some people don't really care about money; they don't care about power, but they want honor. I want to be respected; I want to have the titles that I deserve. So, I hop around that altar from the time I'm a little kid, and I get a little buzz from when I receive an honor, but then I need a higher honor than that. I need someone beyond my father to honor me. I need someone beyond my high school teachers to honor me. I need someone beyond my university professors to honor me. I need honor all the time. I'm like an honor junkie, so I'm hopping around the altar. Think of the slashing of the arms. It's the pain that addiction causes us. It's the pain that addiction causes us.

- 4.55 But I don't care how much you rave. "They raved on until the time of the offering, and there was no voice, no answer, no response." The fire was not going to fall. I think this image of the altars to the priests, to the Baals, is a master image for understanding a lot of the anguish of our human lives. We're hopping around the wrong darn altars all the time.
- 4.56 Here's something from Saint John of the Cross, as I mentioned, the greatest spiritual master in the Catholic tradition. John of the Cross said that we have in us an infinite cavern. What he means is it's the infinite longing for God. It's an infinite hunger because only God can fill it. But what's the tragedy of life? He says that we take all these finite things, wealth, pleasure, honor, all that, and then we throw it into the cavern. That'll satisfy me. And what does it do? It just goes to the bottom. Oh, wait a minute . I must need more of it because I'm not satisfied yet. So, more of it, more of it. I keep throwing it down the cavern, and it does nothing. It doesn't fill me up in any way. I've been hopping around the wrong altar.
- 4.57 Then, Elijah has his time, and he makes the prayer to the Lord, and the fire falls and consumes the sacrifice. But again, please don't read this as just a jingoistic story of, 'I got the cooler God than you do.' It's telling this truth. It's only when we hook the infinite desire in our hearts onto the infinite God that we will find something like satisfaction. Only that way will the fire fall.
- 4.58 Now, let me take one more little step here. What does it mean to honor the true God, to give worship to the true God? It's to become aligned to the one who is love. What's love? Love is self-gift . The trouble with the altars to the Baals is that it's all about filling up my ego. When you worship the true God, whose name is love, you become aligned to self-gift. When does the fire fall? When you find a way to give away the grace you've been given. That's the best manner in which we give honor to God. That's when the fire falls.
- 4.59 That little story, everybody, I think is so clarifying. I've used it in my pastoral work for years, in pastoral counseling, because I mentioned the other day about Paul Tillich that all you need to know about someone, you learn from asking the one question: what do you worship? If someone comes in great anguish, that's the question I tend to ask. Name the altar you've been hopping around most of your life. It's something.
- 4.60 By the way, the New Testament correspondence here is the woman at the well, the woman that comes every day to the well, and she drinks and gets thirsty. What does Jesus say to her? "You come every day to this well, you drink, and you're thirsty again, don't you? I want to give you water welling up in you to eternal life." Stop going to the well of money, pleasure, power, honor, whatever it is. Stop going to that well. It won't satisfy you. Rather , align yourself to me, and I'm going to give you water bubbling up, meaning water overflowing, not water that you hang on to that's yours, but you become a vehicle of grace. That's how it works. That's how it works. That's the biblical teaching that I think is of tremendous relevance today.

- 4.61** Let me do one last one in this segment. I want to go now to the greatest of the literary prophets, namely Isaiah. Isaiah, Chapter 6—there it is—is the account of Isaiah's call . So, remember, go back to lecture one, our basic framework of getting into right relationship with the true God. The whole Bible is about that. The whole Bible is about that. It's, as I say, ringing the changes or its permutations and combinations of that story of how we get in line with God. And this is really clarifying, I think, when we see it symbolically.
- 4.62** Here's Isaiah telling us about how he came to be a prophet. It's chapter 6. "In the year that King Uzziah died, I saw the Lord sitting on a throne, high and lofty, and the hem of his robe filled the temple." I think it's beautiful that he specifies the time. "It was the year that King Uzziah died." Aren't there times in our lives when the Lord breaks through? When we hear the voice, I mentioned that yesterday. We're shifting metaphors here, but it's Abraham hearing not the voices of the world, but hearing the voice of the Unconditional, hearing the voice of God, of the summum bonum, that can come through the voices of the world, but it's not identical to them. This higher voice.
- 4.63** Here, Isaiah has a breakthrough. He sees something. For me, I was a 14-year-old kid, and I was a baseball player. I wanted to be a professional baseball player when I was that age. Priesthood was the furthest thing from my mind. I was in a freshman religion class, and one of the young teachers, he was a Dominican priest, taught us one of Thomas Aquinas's arguments for God's existence.
- 4.64** I believed in God. It wasn't like I was an atheist or anything, but there was something about that that— I don't know. To this day, I can't really explain it. It sang to me at such a deep level that I got on my 10-speed bike, and I rode to the local library, and I got this big tome of Thomas Aquinas. I had no business even trying to read it. I tucked it under my shirt, and I rode home with it. I started reading this, and it's no kidding. I'm standing in front of you right now as a bishop of the church because of that, because of that day. It was 1974, the spring of 1974. I can name it. And that's Isaiah. In the year that King Uzziah died—" he can name it, too. When the Lord spoke to him, he broke through into his consciousness.
- 4.65** It's important to find that in your own life. It's important to find that moment. When was that? What did he see? "I saw the Lord sitting on a throne, high and lofty , and the hem of his robe filled the temple." Remember from lecture one? God is that which cannot be grasped, cannot be hidden from. "High on a lofty throne" is a symbolic talk for transcendent. What Isaiah sensed was the transcendence of God. But "the hem of his robe filled the temple," yet he was also present here below in this temple. God can't be grasped, can't be hidden from. That's the vision he's having.
- 4.66** "Seraphs were in attendance above him; each had six wings." The seraph, seraphim in Hebrew, means 'the burnt ones.' They're burnt by their proximity to the fire of God. That's the idea. The intensity of God's being. Remember, I said Aquinas calls God Actus Purus, or 'pure energy.' Pure energy, like the sun. The closer you get, you get burnt.

That's what seraph means, 'the one who's been burnt.' So, with the Lord, he sees these figures that are burnt by their proximity to him.

- 4.67** "One call to the other:"—these are the angels speaking to each other—"Holy, Holy, Holy is the Lord of hosts; the whole Earth is full of his glory." We echo this in the liturgy, don't we? "Holy, Holy, Holy Lord God of hosts." We sing this same song, "Kadosh, Kadosh, Kadosh," in Hebrew. It means 'other, other, other.' That's what it means: 'other, other, other .' 'Strange, strange, strange.' God can't be grasped, "and the whole Earth is full of his glory." There we go. There's the Bible. Not just he's other, other, other. That could be deism, or that could be ultimately atheism. But he's other , other, other, and his glory fills the Earth. You can't run from him. You can't hide from him.
- 4.68** Isaiah is witnessing here beautifully to the God I was trying lamely to describe, the God that comes up out of this biblical experience. Then, listen as he goes on. "The pivots on the threshold shook at the voice of those who call the house filled with smoke." All that shaking of the foundations is what happens when God breaks into your life; the foundations of your building are shaken. The thing you think is absolutely basic and unchanging is going to be shaken by the presence of God.
- 4.69** Notice, too, here that this happens to Isaiah. He's not trying to make this happen. It's not some effort of his. God manifests himself. God makes himself available available to us. It's what I call the invasion of grace. The spiritual life has to begin with that because we're not in control of it. If I'm in control, it's not God I'm talking about anymore. God's got to be in control. So, the Holy One comes. The pivots shake. My assumptions and my worldview and all that shakes.
- 4.70** Now, here's the second step in the spiritual life, and this is across the board. So, first is the manifestation. Things that happen. I can still feel, by the way, after all these years, I can still feel the joy that I felt after that experience in high school. I can still feel the joy of it. And that's what Isaiah is telling us. He can still feel it, too. But then listen. "And I said, 'Woe is me! I'm lost, for I'm a man of unclean lips. I live among a people of unclean lips, yet my eyes have seen the King, the Lord of hosts!'"
- 4.71** The second step in the spiritual life is knowing that you're a sinner. Notice, please, it doesn't start with the knowledge of sin. That's getting the spiritual life off on the wrong foot. It just is. If you say, "I'm beginning with this keen sense that I'm a terrible sinner," you're not going to get the thing off on the right foot. It begins with the invasion of grace. It begins with a gift, with a gift.
- 4.72** Now, once you're in the presence of God, in Kadosh, Kadosh, Kadosh, Holy, Holy , Holy, yet his glory fills the earth. I'm in the presence of the Unconditioned Actus Purus. What inevitably happens? You become aware of your own sin. It works that way. It's like I'm from Chicago. Now, I'm in Minnesota, so it still applies . You're driving in the wintertime, and all this gunk is kicked up on your windshield and salt and all this business. And if you're driving at night away from direct light, you can see okay out the

window. But the next morning, you're driving directly east into the rising sun. You can't see a thing because the light has revealed to you the imperfection on the windshield.

4.73 The same thing is true in the spiritual order. "Hey, I'm fine." Remember that book, this stupid book, I'm Ok - You're Ok? I don't know anything that's less true than that. I'm okay and you're okay? We're both hopeless. We're both lost. Only someone that's driving away from the light could ever say, "Hey, I'm fine. I'm doing just great." That's almost a guarantee that you're not driving toward the light. But now, you've turned your life around, or better, the light has come to you. The light has come to you. What do you know? I'm a sinner. You say exactly what he says, "Whoa, wait a minute. Woe is me! I am lost. I'm a man of unclean lips." It's his metaphor for I'm a bad guy. "I'm among a people of unclean lips." All my people are bad. That's the way it works. The closer God gets, the more we are aware of our sin, not the less.

4.74 I even notice this in the lives of the saints. When you first read it, you think, "Oh, come on. It's false modesty." But all the saints will say things like, "I'm the worst of sinners." The Little Flower, Thérèse of Lisieux, this very innocent nun, joins the convent at 15. She dies at 24, having never left the convent, this sweet, wonderful woman. Read her writings. The worst of sinners. How could you say that? Because she's driving toward the light. She's driving toward the light. The fact that I say, "Oh, no, I'm doing great." I'm driving the wrong way. So, the saints—that's okay. You should say, "Woe is me! I'm lost."

4.75 But then watch, does God dwell on that? "Yes, you are a loser. Yes, woe should be to you, and I've had it with you." No, no, listen, what happens. "One of the seraphs flew to me, holding a live coal that had been taken from the altar with a pair of tongues. The seraph touched my mouth with it and said, 'Now that this has touched your lips, your guilt has departed. Your sin is blotted out.' Then I heard the voice of the Lord saying, 'Whom shall I send? Who will go for us?' And I said, 'Here I am; send me!'"

4.76 There's the spiritual life, everybody. The breakthrough of grace, the light comes. Unbidden. I can't control that. It comes. But in its presence, I realize I'm a sinner. Good. That's healthy. That's good. You should know you're a sinner. But God doesn't dwell on that. No, what he's interested in is purifying us of our sin, so the fiery side of that light now comes through the coal that's going to clean the unclean lips of Isaiah.

4.77 Good. That's what God wants. He wants us to be fully alive and to forgive our sins and then comes always the third moment in the spiritual journey, which is mission. "I heard the voice of the Lord saying, 'Whom shall I send? Who will go?'" And Isaiah goes, "I'm your man. I'll go." So it goes, inevitably, in the Bible, as I mentioned, no one is ever given an experience of God without being at the same time sent on a mission.

4.78 Can I give you a parallel text, and I'll bring it to a close with this? I want to go to the New Testament. Luke, Chapter 5 is a parallel text to Isaiah, Chapter 6. Listen now. "Once, while Jesus was standing beside the Lake of Gennesaret, and the crowd was

pressing in on him to hear the word of God, he saw two boats there at the shore of the lake; the fishermen had gone out of them and were washing their nets. He got into one of the boats, the one belonging to Simon, and asked to put out a little way from the shore."

- 4.79** What do we notice here? We're on the seashore. These are Galilean fishermen. Their boat? That was everything, man. The boat was their livelihood. That's how they lived. So, a fisherman and his boat? It's like someone came along and just got in your car with no permission. Just, "I'm getting in your car . Move over. I'm getting in, and let me tell you where we're going." What are you talking about? A fortiori, a boat for a fisherman , was everything. It was his life.
- 4.80** Jesus gets in the boat. This is the invasion of grace. This is Isaiah in the temple, suddenly seeing the presence of the Lord. Unbidden, he gets in the boat. This is the way it works in the spiritual order. The Lord gets in our boat without being asked, without our cooperation. He gets in the boat and begins giving commands. And what's the command he gives is, "You got to go out into deeper water." And that's the way it always works, spiritually.
- 4.81** What do we do, most of us sinners? We hug the shore in our little boats that we're in command of. We want to play it safe. We want to avoid danger and make sure we're under control. The minute God gets in the boat, we're going out into deeper water because that's where life is. That's where the fish are. You're not going to find them here. That's why this view that spiritual people are little cowards and little nerds. It's the opposite in the biblical vision. It's the worldly people that are the ones who are fearfully logging the shore . It's the adventurers. The Lord gets in your boat, and out you go.
- 4.82** And what follows, of course, is the miraculous draft of fishes. They bring in more fish than they can positively handle. So it goes. When you let God in your life, what should you expect? Life. "Abraham, I know you're an old man, and your wife's an old lady, but trust me, you're going to be the father of many nations. Look up at the stars. Count them if you can. Your descendants will be more than that. Thirty, sixty, hundredfold." When you worship the true God, when you let God direct your life, life is multiplied in you.
- 4.83** So, they fill the boats with the fish and now watch. "But when Simon Peter saw it , he fell down at Jesus' knees, saying, 'Go away from me, Lord, for I'm a sinful man!'" Good. Right. That's step two, inevitably. In the light, you know you're a sinner. In the presence of this miracle of grace, Peter knows he's a sinner. Good, good. That's the second step. Know you're a sinner. Acknowledge it.
- 4.84** But watch again how the Lord deals with this. "Then Jesus said to Simon, 'Do not be afraid. From now on, you'll be catching people.' When they brought their boats to shore, they left everything and followed him." There's the third step. Grace, the

invasion of grace. Jesus gets in the boat. Secondly, he knows he's a sinner. Okay, okay, we're all sinners. We're all addicts. But the Lord doesn't want us dwelling on that. He doesn't want to stay with that in a reproachful way. No, he offers forgiveness. And then, what? Sends. Send. From now on, you'll be catching people. I got a mission for you. I got a mission for you. Go, go out in the world now. You've received grace. Give it away as a grace.

4.85 Isaiah, Chapter 6 and Luke, Chapter 5 are parallel accounts, but you'll find them throughout the Bible in that same rhythm. You find the center. The light comes to you, the invasion of grace. You know you're a sinner, but then you realize your life is not about you. That's a phrase I think sums up a lot of the spiritual life. To know that your life is not about you. It's about what God wants to accomplish through you. And when you find that, you come alive.

Lecture 5: Contrasting Powers

At a glance — Contrasting powers.

- 5.1 Well, we've been romping our way through the Old Testament, looking at these fundamental questions: who is God, and what's the right relationship to God? We see from the prophets, from the psalmist, and from the various authors ringing of the changes on those great themes.
- 5.2 I'm a catholic bishop, so I'm going to get to the New Testament, and that's going to be these last two lectures. But I want to make one last stop in the Old Testament to look at one of my favorite books, one of the quirkiest, strangest, shortest books in the Old Testament, and one that is really punched above its weight in the tradition. Here's three pages, and yet it has intrigued poets, philosophers, artists, and so on over the centuries. I'm talking about the Book of the prophet Jonah.
- 5.3 Here's one of the quirky things about it. It's not about Jonah's preaching. In fact, the one sermon he gives is like three words in Hebrew. That's all we ever hear about the content of his preaching. What the book is about is Jonah. We're meant to look at him. Because he's a great spiritual hero? Not exactly. He's a compromised figure, but in the moves and machinations of Jonah, we learn a lot about how to relate to the living God. So, listen to how this book begins.
- 5.4 "The word of the Lord came to Jonah son of Amittai, saying, 'Go at once to Nineveh, that great city.' So, first of all, he's heard the voice, the voice of the Unconditioned, the voice of God, the voice beyond the voices of the world. Like Abraham, like all the great figures of Israel, Jonah has heard this higher voice.
- 5.5 Now, the instinctual reaction is to say, "That's wonderful, isn't it?" when you hear the voice of God. Who wouldn't want that? God spoke to me. Often, in the Bible, that's about the last thing you want. The voice of God can be a very disruptive voice to those of us—we're all sinners here—who have organized our lives in the wrong way. The voice of God is going to be a deeply challenging voice. So, Jonah is not really happy because, listen, as the voice gets really specific.
- 5.6 "Go once to Nineveh, that great city, and cry out against it, for their wickedness has come up before me." So, Jonah is an Israelite. Nineveh is the capital city of the Assyrian empire, the great enemy of Israel. Syria has been brutally oppressive toward Israel. "So, Jonah, get up by yourself, just you, go to the capital city, this great city, of the enemy nation, and don't say nice things to them. On the contrary, tell them how bad they are. Call them to justice and judgment."
- 5.7 Well, look, sometimes, when the voice of God speaks to us, we do not want to listen. I mentioned yesterday that often, the voice of God is channeled or expressed through the voice of the conscience. When our conscience tells us, "Look, this is the right thing

to do." Difficult? Yes, very often. Will it get you in a lot of trouble? Probably. Won't make you popular? Very good chance. But it's your conscience telling you, "Here's what you should do." That's where we are as the book gets underway. What do you do in that situation?

- 5.8** Listen to what Jonah does. "Jonah set out to flee to Tarshish from the presence of the Lord." To get the geography, Nineveh would be east by land from where he is. "Okay, Lord, I've heard your voice, so I'm going to go as far as I can in the opposite direction. Tarshish." The scholars debate where exactly that was. The consensus seems to be what they used to call the pillars of Hercules, that point where Europe and Africa meet at the far western edge of the Mediterranean. The point is, if that's what Tarshish refers to, it's like our saying Timbuktu. I'm going to Timbuktu; I'm going to go as far away as I possibly can.
- 5.9** Well, there it is, fellow sinners. That's the reaction we often have to the voice of conscience, to the voice of the Lord. I'm going to hightail it out of town. So, he went down to Joppa and found a ship going to Tarshish. He paid his fare and went on board, to go with them to Tarshish, away from the presence of the Lord. The boat sets out, and what happens? Storms kick up immediately. What's the lesson? You can't resist the call of God with impunity.
- 5.10** Don't think, if you're going against the deepest desires of God, that somehow everything's going to be fine. No, not because God's being capricious or because God wants arbitrarily to punish us. Again, it's spiritual physics. Just as the rebellion of Adam and Eve led from the garden to the desert, here, resistance to God's will leads to storms.
- 5.11** Now, more to it. Jonah is not alone on this ship. He's with shipmates, with many others. The storm is threatening them as much as it is Jonah. They're panicking, the people on the ship, and they're—"Look, someone on this boat must have done something wrong. That's why this is happening." And eventually, to his credit, Jonah says, "Yeah, it's me. I'm the one."
- 5.12** But here's the spiritual point. When I was a professor at the seminary, and eventually, I was a rector of the seminary, my job there was to help people discern their call from God. Does God want you to be a priest or not? And you can look at that very individualistically, like, "This is a decision I have to make about my own life." That's never the case, is it? Because in God, we're all connected to each other.
- 5.13** Remember that from Brother Sun, Sister Moon? If God is Ipsum Esse, the sheer act of to be itself, all finite things are grounded in God. Therefore, they're connected to each other. I mentioned that when you pray and you find your deepest center in God, you found the deepest center of everybody else and everything else in the universe. We are willy-nilly connected to each other. Therefore, my resistance to God's call is not just bad for me; it's bad for the people around me. It kicks up storms for them as well.

- 5.14** I think, everybody, it's a very important point when we're doing spiritual discernment. This is not just about me. Every decision I make with regard to the deepest purpose of my life will affect people around me for weal or for woe. I mentioned the saints with the halos. That's the idea of the saint becoming a source of illumination for the people around him or her. Well, the same way the sinner, the one who's rebelling against God, becomes a source of storms, danger for those around.
- 5.15** So then, we hear the sailors say to each other, "Come, let's cast lots so we can know on whose account this calamity has come upon us." The lots fell on Jonah. Jonah goes, "I admit it. I'm the one. I'm running away from God." So, they throw him overboard, and the storm is calmed. Okay, good.
- 5.16** But what happens next? Not the end of Jonah, but rather the great fish, usually depicted as a whale. It's not called a whale. It's just called a big fish coming up from these primordial depths. Now, remember the *tohu wa-bohu* again. When the Bible talks about primal seas and watery chaos, it's calling to mind that opening of the Bible. Up from this great abyss comes the fish, who, at God's prompting, swallows up Jonah.
- 5.17** Now, how do we read this spiritually? Jonah's problem was his rebellious will. He decided, "I'm going to go in the opposite direction of what God wants." So, his will needed to be swallowed up. His freedom—remember we talked about freedom the other day? Freedom is not just a choice, like, "I decide what I want to do." No, freedom is the disciplining of desire so as to make the achievement of the good first possible, then effortless. So, the fish swallowing up Jonah and restricting his will is, in fact, freeing him, in fact, making him free, compelling him finally to do what God wants him to do.
- 5.18** Think about that confinement in the fish going through the watery depths. Think of the worst times in your life, and we've all had them. Times of great fear, depression, and anxiety. Times when we feel like, "I don't know where I'm going. I've lost my bearings. I feel stuck." That's where Jonah is. That's where Jonah is.
- 5.19** One of the most beautiful prayers—I love it—in the scriptures comes out of the mouth of Jonah. Listen. "I called to the Lord out of my distress, and he answered me; out of the belly of Sheol, I cried, and you heard my voice. You cast me into the deep, into the heart of the seas. The floods surrounded me. All your waves, your billows passed over me. Then I said, 'I'm driven away from your sight. How shall I look again upon your holy temple?' The waters closed in over me; the deep surrounded me; weeds were wrapped around my head."
- 5.20** You know what I love about that? It's a prayer with such honesty. He's speaking "de Profundis," we say, "out of the depths." He's describing what it's like to be in that place, but he's placing his own restriction, depression, limitation, and anxiety in the presence of God. That's a saving move. Not to read that as simply, "I've been abandoned by God." No, to bring—and somehow that image of the weeds wrapped around his head—

he's inside the fish and the seaweed around his head. It's naming these worst times in our lives but bringing that to God.

- 5.21** He's going on in prayer, "As my life was ebbing away, I remembered you, Lord, and my prayer came to you into your holy temple. Those who worship vain idols forsake their true loyalty. But I, with the voice of thanksgiving, will sacrifice to you." There's that language of idolatry, which is always the primordial problem. I'm worshipping something other than God. Jonah, to his great credit, while he's in the belly of the fish, prays out of that condition and offers praise to the true God.
- 5.22** What's happening is his errant rebellious will, having been swallowed up, is now being brought back on line. How do we read our times of depression, anxiety, fear, and limitation? Dumb suffering, or can we read them as God's way of bringing us back on line to him? That's the interesting question.
- 5.23** So then, what do we hear? "Then the Lord spoke to the fish, and it spewed Jonah out upon the dry land." Remember, "Jonah, go east by land to Nineveh." He went west by sea to Tarshish. The fish swallows him up, carries him through the deep, and spews him out exactly where God wants him to be. What's happening in these times of deep struggle in our lives? Could it be precisely God's way of limiting our errant will and bringing us back exactly where he wants us to be?
- 5.24** And then, what follows? Again, this is the whole Book of Jonah. I'm on page two. There's page three. That's how short this book is. So now, "The word of the Lord comes to Jonah a second time, saying, 'Get up, go to Nineveh'" — figure this out, Jonah. You can't avoid me. Remember? God is ungraspable but also unavoidable. Stop trying to avoid me and listen again to my voice—" proclaim to it the message that I tell you."
- 5.25** So, Jonah sets out, and he enters, all by himself, one single figure, into the capital city of the great enemy of his people. And then, here's the sermon. In English, it's a few words, in Hebrew three. "Forty days more, Nineveh shall be overthrown." That's all he says. Up and down the streets, "forty days more and you'll be overthrown."
- 5.26** And then, here's the part that I think is very comical. "When the news reached the king, he rose from his throne, removed his robe, covered himself with sackcloth, and sat in ashes." So, right away, the king repents. Well, that means the whole city is going to follow, probably. And then, we hear that all the people covered themselves in ashes, and then even the animals covered themselves in sackcloth and ashes. Jonah becomes, in short, the most efficacious preacher of repentance in the history of the Bible.
- 5.27** What happens when we finally surrender to the promptings of God? Remember, "Thirty, sixty, and a hundredfold." Remember, "Look at the stars in the sky. Your descendants will be more than those if you can count them." When you finally get aligned to God, extraordinary power of grace flows through you. That's it. That's it. That's the Bible. When you worship, remember, you get a line to God, then his grace can flow through you powerfully into the world.

- 5.28** At that point, you'd say, all right, happy ending. I get it. In the Book of Jonah, he resisted, God restricted him, put him where he wanted to be, and then the whole city repented. Happy ending. Well, not quite. Here we come to a very peculiar, wonderfully peculiar part of the Bible. In almost all the ancient literature of the world, you find that people will valorize, even apotheosize, their political leaders. The kings of Babylon, Assyria, and Rome are deified. They're like gods. The Bible? The Bible is sharply critical of kings. Sharply critical of its kings. Look at even David. The great David is an adulterer and a murderer. The Bible is very clear-eyed about the failure of kings.
- 5.29** In the same way, the Bible is very clear-eyed about the corruption of religion. Even as it's all about religion, it's all about fostering a spiritual life. Yeah, but very often, the representatives of the spiritual life are corrupt. Where do we see it? Not just in Jonah's rebellion, at the beginning. Listen to what he says now as all of Nineveh repents. You think he'd be delighted. No, no. "This was very displeasing to Jonah. And he became angry. He prayed to the Lord and said, 'Oh, Lord, is not this what I said while I was still in my own country? That is why I fled to Tarshish at the beginning; for I knew you are a gracious God and merciful, slow to anger, abounding in steadfast love.'"
- 5.30** Now, we didn't know that at the beginning. He didn't tell us that. All we heard was, "Jonah, go on this mission." And Jonah goes, "No, I'm going to Tarshish." But now, at the end, he tells us, "This is why I resisted you, Lord. Not just because it's a tough assignment; I resisted you because I know what you're like. You're kind and merciful, and deep down, I'd like you to send fire and brimstone on those Ninevites. That's what I would like. I want to be a prophet of doom and gloom, and I want you to come through and rain fire and brimstone down." He knows God's not going to do it. In fact, God is rich in mercy.
- 5.31** Jonah's not rejoicing in the repentance of Nineveh, as he should. He's frustrated. And then, he sits down on a hill outside the city to watch and wait. He wants Sodom and Gomorrah. "I want to see some fire and brimstone around here." It doesn't happen. It's very good caution, everybody, all of us who are interested in religion and the things of religion. Do we resist God? That's one question. But secondly, do we really believe the God that we preach, the God who is nothing but love, the God who wants all people to be saved, the God who reaches out in love? Yes, even to our enemies. Even to our enemies. Even those we'd like, "Lord, smite them!" Jonah's frustration is a judgment on all of us.
- 5.32** Anyway, that's just a little bit—if you want to hear the very best sermon, read the very best sermon on Jonah, get the wonderful American novel *Moby Dick* by Herman Melville. Father Mapple is a character. As the crew is setting out on their great journey, they come to this chapel and the pulpit is like the prow of a ship coming out, and up into the pulpit climbs Father Mapple, who's an old seaman himself, and he gives this stirring homily on Jonah. That's the best one. We can keep pulling spiritual truth out of this one forever.

- 5.33** With that, I'm going to turn to the New Testament. But what I've been doing so far is preparing the way. Here's a basic intuition of our whole tradition. You will not understand Jesus without understanding the Old Testament. There was a movement very early in the church, which goes back to the second century, called Marcianism.
- 5.34** Marcion was a Roman theologian, a Christian theologian, who said, "The Old Testament is the testament to a fallen God. That's the cruel, violent, capricious God and all that. Let's get rid of him. The true God's revealed in Jesus." So, he wanted to excise the whole Testament and, in fact, many parts of the New Testament. And the church—and I say it to its infinite credit; it was a very important move early on—said no to Marcion. Said no to marcionism. You can't understand Jesus apart from the Old Testament, and the same God is speaking in both the Old and the New Testaments.
- 5.35** Now, here's how I would put it. What have I been talking about for all these lectures? God and the human being in right or wrong relation to God. What does it look like to be in the stance of worship of the true God? What does it look like to be off-kilter? What are all the institutions of Israel? Whether it's the covenant made with Abraham, whether it's the law given to Moses, whether it's the Temple built by David and Solomon, what's the whole point of all these institutions? Whether it's the words of the prophets, they're all meant to reconcile divinity and humanity, to bring them together. Torah, covenant, prophecy, the Temple, all of it.
- 5.36** But deep within the heart of the Old Testament is a conviction—and this is, I think, true for a Jew or a Christian reading the Old Testament—a deep conviction that though this is what was desired, it hasn't fully happened. Very often, the Torah is violated. Very often, the covenant's broken. Very often, the law is not followed. Very often, they don't listen to the prophets. So, what begins to emerge now from the very heart of Israel? Do you want to find it? Look, especially in the Psalms and the prophets, this messianic longing.
- 5.37** Mashiach means 'the anointed one.' It's David because the prophet Samuel anoints David and says, "The spirit of the Lord rushed upon David." I've always loved that line. So, David is the 'Mashiach par excellence.' But the Old Testament now begins to dream of a definitive David, a new David, a son of David. At the same time, these are very mysterious texts. Yes, a human figure is being anticipated, another David. At the same time, again, look at the Psalms and the prophets. God himself says, "I will come and shepherd my people. I myself." The shepherds of Israel have left the sheep scattered on the hillside. "I myself will come to shepherd them." A Davidic figure and God himself.
- 5.38** What did the first Christians see? I think the best way to put it is that they saw in this Yeshua, this Jesus from Nazareth, that figure. A son of David, I mentioned this the other day, the genealogy in Matthew, 14 generations: David, David, David. How often he's called the son of David? How often there's a messianic expectation around him? But also he, strangely, is the God of Israel in person, come to shepherd his people.

- 5.39** Now, where do we see it? Can I suggest that on almost every page of the Gospels? It is not the case to say that this assertion of Jesus' divinity is something unique to the Gospel of John. No, no, no. It's on practically every page of the Gospels. Can I give you a couple of examples?
- 5.40** So Jesus—and, obviously, a human figure; no one's doubting that—Jesus says to the man, "My son, your sins are forgiven." And right away, those around him say correctly, "Who does this man think he is? Only God can forgive sins." Uh-huh. That statement is every bit as high a Christology—that's a technical term for one that stresses the divinity of Jesus—that's every bit as high a Christology as "in the beginning was the word." Jesus says, "My son, your sins are forgiven." Yeah. Only God can forgive sins.
- 5.41** How about this? Jesus says, "You've heard it said, but I say—" That's the beginning of the sermon on the mount. You've heard it said in the Torah. That's the implication. You've heard it said in the very highest authority within the Jewish religion because the Torah was revealed directly by God to Moses. "You've heard it said there, but I say—" Who could possibly say that coherently except the one who is himself the author of the Torah?
- 5.42** Did they sense this? You bet. You hear it in the Gospels. "This man speaks with authority." That's what they meant. The word in Greek there is *exousia*. It's a lovely word. *Exousia* means 'substance.' *Exousia* means 'out of the substance of' because every teacher in Judaism would say, "I learned this from my teacher, rabbi so and so, who learned it from his teacher, rabbi so and so, rabbi so and so, back, back, back until we come to Mount Sinai and Moses, who learned it from God. That's how you claimed authority. You stood in a long tradition. Then, there's Jesus. "You've heard it said." Yeah, in the Torah. "But I say—" Who is this man that speaks with that kind of authority?
- 5.43** How about this? "Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will never pass away." Now, you say, "Jesus, sure, he's a prophet, he's a great teacher and all that." But what if I were to say to you—you've listened to me for a couple of days now—"Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will never pass away." you'd think I'd lost my mind, and you'd be right. Who is this guy? Who does he think he is? "Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will never pass away." That's what Jesus says.
- 5.44** This one, too, we might find elusive, but no one in the first century would have missed it. "The son of man is the Lord of the Sabbath," he says. The Lord of the Sabbath? What are you talking about? The Sabbath was established by God at the creation of the world. The Sabbath is the Lord's day. That's what it is. We human beings practice the Sabbath so we can give honor to God. To say that "I'm the lord of the Sabbath"—there was only one Lord of the Sabbath: the Creator God. Those are all from the synoptic Gospels, all these citations.

- 5.45** In the Gospel of John, you have this more explicit language. "In the beginning was the Word. The Word was with God. The Word was God. The Word became flesh and dwelt among us." You find, for example, "Before Abraham was,"—Jesus says—"I am." Again and again, In John's Gospel, "I am the bread of life. I am the good shepherd. I am the vine; you're the branches." When they come to get him in the garden of Gethsemane, they are looking for Jesus, he says, "I am." The word there, the phrase is, "Ego eimi. I am."
- 5.46** In the Greek translation of the Old Testament where we began these lectures, "Lord, what's your name? When they ask me what your name is, what should I tell them?" "I am who I am." The Greek of that was, "Ego eimi ho on. I am the one who is." So, Jesus is saying over and over again, "Ego eime, ego eime, ego eime, I am."
- 5.47** We are not talking about a mere prophet. That's the point the Gospels are making again and again. We're not talking about one more in a long line of prophets, but rather, what? The one in whose very person divinity and humanity have met. What Israel longed for, what all the institutions of Israel were created to produce, has happened. Divinity and humanity have met.
- 5.48** Can I do a little more theology, a little more technical theology with you before we get back into the texts themselves? So, this is what's been bequeathed to the first Christians. I think you can see it in the pages of the New Testament this conviction about Jesus, but it took several centuries for the church to figure out how exactly to express this, how precisely to say it. How do we state correctly the coming together of divinity and humanity?
- 5.49** Can I give you three bad options, all entertained in the ancient church? One bad option is called monophysitism. Physis means 'nature' in Greek, monos means 'one.' The monophysite said, "Jesus is God." His humanity is an afterthought, an appendage, or a secondary thing. He's one nature. He's divine. There's an extreme form of monophysitism called docetism, from the Greek word dokeo, which means 'to seem' or 'to appear.' That view was that Jesus is God, who appears to be human. He's got a human appearance. That's one extreme.
- 5.50** Go to the other extreme: Nestorianism, named for an early bishop called Nestorius. He said, "Sure, Jesus is like a super saint." So, a saint, we say, is someone who has a close relationship to God, a great friendship with God. Jesus is the ultimate example of that. He's the saint of saints. Take Mother Teresa, Francis of Assisi, and then Jesus would be the limit case of a guy with a really, really powerful friendship with God. The Nestorians say he's, basically, a human being who has this relationship to God that we can have, too, to a lesser degree. Now, easy to understand. Yeah, and I would say a lot of people today, when they think about Jesus, probably are kind of Nestorian. "Oh, yeah, what a great hero, a great spiritual figure."

- 5.51** So, monophysitism and Nestorianism. There's also a compromise position called Arianism, named for an Alexandrian priest called Arius, who made this argument. He said, "No, Jesus is quasi-divine and quasi-human." So, he's not fully divine. He's a very high creature of God who's now united to a quasi-humanity. He's linked to a human body. So, you bring this quasi-divine into line with a quasi-human, and you get this third thing we're going to call Jesus.
- 5.52** It might seem a little weird to us, but think of the ancient world; Achilles, Hercules, people like that were demigods, half divine, half human. So, Arius is saying, "That's kind of what we have with Jesus. He's sort of like Hercules or Achilles." Now, here's what I want you to see—again, give these people their due. They're all trying to figure out how to make sense of the fact that he's the coming together of divinity and humanity.
- 5.53** In 451, the church gathered at a place called Chalcedon. Chalcedon was a suburb of Constantinople, so it's outside of Istanbul today. The church, bishops, theologians, and fathers gathered at Chalcedon to finally work this thing out. The year was 451, and what Chalcedon said was, "No, no, and no." It said no to monophysitism, it said no to Arianism, and it said no to Nestorianism.
- 5.54** What does Chalcedon say? "In Jesus, two natures, fully divine and fully human, come together in the unity of one person without mixing, mingling, or confusion." Let me say that again, and I know I'm using kind of technical, philosophical language now, but what I want you to see is how deeply biblical this finally is. In Jesus, person, come together two natures: fully human nature and fully divine nature without mixing, mingling, or confusion. Not a demigod, not a demi-human, not just God, not just human—fully divine and fully human.
- 5.55** You say, "All right, I get it, but how do we make sense of that?" Can we go right back to the burning bush out of which God spoke to Moses and revealed his name? Not, "I'm a really high being. I'm one of the most impressive beings in the universe." No. "I am who I am." The bush is on fire but not consumed. God is fully present, and yet the bush is itself, in fact, more beautifully and fully itself. The divine is presence not pushing anything out but making the finite beautiful, elevating it.
- 5.56** What do we see in Jesus? Precisely that because God is not one being among many, he's not in competition with the world. If I were to say, "I want to sit in your chair," you have to get out of the chair for me to sit in it. Or if I say, "I'm going to be in control of your life." Well, then, you've got to give way. You have to surrender to me. There's a competitiveness about finite things. If I were to say, "I can turn this podium into ash." Yeah, by destroying it. The fire would destroy it. Finite things are competitive with each other in that way.
- 5.57** Then, there's God, who's not a finite thing, not one being among many. Therefore, God can become a creature; that's to say, he can take a creaturely nature to himself without destroying it, without eliminating it, without competing with it, in fact, making it, in the

process, beautiful, enhanced, and compelling. Ah, that's what the council of Chalcedon said. Jesus, fully God, fully human, his humanity elevated, perfected, precisely by the proximity of his divinity.

- 5.58** From a Christian standpoint, what is this? Salvation. This is salvation. That word's lovely. Salvation comes from the Latin *salus*, which means 'health.' If you were greeting somebody in the ancient world, the Roman world, you would have said, "Salve, salve." We still even have that in Spanish or in Italian. Salve. 'Health to you.' That's what it means: Hey, 'good health to you.' Look at the word *salve*. S-A-L-V-E. That's our English word, *salve*. Right, right. What's a *salve* but a healing balm that we put on to heal a wound?
- 5.59** Take one more step. Jesus is called the Savior. It's right from that word, the Savior, the one who *salves* a broken and painful human condition, and it happens through the proximity of his divinity. Do we wonder now why Jesus becomes himself a source of healing to all those around him? Well, no, he himself is salvation. He himself is the overcoming of the rift.
- 5.60** It also explains why first-century Jews who come into contact with him will say things like, "He's the fulfillment of the temple. He's the new David. He's the new Moses. He's the law in person. He's the Torah in person." Because everything we've wanted through these institutions has now happened in the coming together of the two natures in Jesus. Does that make sense? I think that's the sort of philosophical and theological framework now for looking at the Gospel texts.
- 5.61** So, in the time I've got left in this lecture, can I start—I want to look at maybe three or four places in the New Testament where this saving dynamic is on display. Let me say this first, though. Saving, yes, indeed, saving—there's a negative side to it, though, too, which is judgment. Will Jesus be the judge of the world? Mm-hm. Why? Because we're all off line. We're all out of step with God. So, when Jesus comes, he's the light, and we're dark by comparison. He's the measuring stick, and we're off-kilter. So, coming into contact with him will always be a little difficult. You see it up and down the Gospels, don't you? Is it a walk in the park to relate to Jesus? Well, no, because he's constantly calling us into a fuller life.
- 5.62** The story of Jesus' arrival into this fallen world, you all know this. I'm reading from Luke, Chapter 2. "In those days, a decree went out from the emperor Augustus that all the world should be registered. This was while Quirinius was governor of Syria. All went to their own towns to be registered. Joseph also went from the town of Nazareth and Galilee to Judea, to the city of David called Bethlehem." A lot is packed in there.
- 5.63** This story begins the way you'd expect this story in the ancient world to begin. They never told stories about common people. They just didn't. That's a much more modern contrivance. In the ancient world, you talked about kings, emperors, generals, and high officials. And so, indeed, Luke commences with Caesar Augustus. He's the emperor of

the world. He's the most powerful person we can imagine. And his local governor, Quairinius, the governor of Syria. All right, I get it. A story about big, important people. It's a story about the world. When you invoke these figures, you invoke the people who were organizing the world at that time. So, that's what we're meant to have in mind.

5.64 Where is this little couple going? They're going to Bethlehem. A first-century Jew would never miss the connection, and it's made explicit. That's the city of David. So, something Davidic is going to happen here, something kingly is going to happen. Right away, we're meant to see something: a tension between worldly kings like Caesar Augustus and this new David who's going to be born.

5.65 Notice, too, how Luke, right away, pulls the rug out from under us because, yeah, we're expecting the story to be about Augustus and Quirinius, but it's not about them at all. They're never mentioned again. It's about this little—who? Nobody? Joseph and his betrothed? These nobodies from Nazareth? It's a little podunk town; nothing important about it. A reversal is going to happen. That's what he's signaling.

5.66 "He went to be registered with Mary, to whom he was engaged and who was expecting a child. While they were there, the time came for her to deliver her child. She gave birth to her firstborn son, wrapped him in bands of cloth, and laid him in a manger because there was no place for them in the inn." We know all the familiar Christmas motifs, but I think we're meant to look at each one with the contrast to Augustus in mind.

5.67 So, first of all, "She wrapped him in bands of cloth." This translation, "swaddling clothes," is the old translation. Beautiful. Think of a baby, a newborn baby. Think when you held one of your children or a niece or nephew. I think of my nephew now. He's this giant kid. He's like 6'7, but when he was a newborn, I held him in one hand like this. So, think of a little tiny baby, and now wrapped up in swaddling clothes. It's hard to imagine anything weaker than that, anything meeker, anything less powerful and impressive.

5.68 Who is the rangiest, freest, and most powerful figure in the ancient world? Augustus Caesar. He's the emperor of the world. He can snap his fingers and get whatever he wants. But who's the true ruler? Who's the true king, the true leader? It's not Augustus. It's this baby who takes the form of weakness and vulnerability.

5.69 "She lays him in a manger." We get romantic about the manger. We've seen a thousand Christmas cards. Manger—mangeorie is the place where animals eat. Gross. A manger is gross. Animals are eating food all day and spitting. It's gross in a manger. So, here's this baby wrapped up in swaddling clothes and placed in this animal feed box. Well, who was the best-fed person in the ancient world? It had to be Caesar Augustus.

5.70 He's living on the Palatine hill. If you go to Rome, you can see the Roman Forum, and you're looking down toward the Colosseum, and you look up to the right, there's the Palatine Hill. Our words, like palace and palazzo and all that, come from that word

because that's where the best and brightest, the most aristocratic lived. And the greatest palace on the Palatine was Caesar Augustus's, the best-fed person. But the true king hasn't come to be fed but placed in the manger to be food for the world.

- 5.71** At the climax of his life, this baby, come of age, will say, "This is my body given for you. This is my blood poured out for you." He's come not to be fed but to feed. And then, the fact that there was no place for them in the inn. Again, who's the best-housed person in the ancient world? Caesar. In his palace on the Palatine. He had the best roof over his head of anybody in the ancient world. This baby, king, has no place to lay his head. Even the crummy traveler's hostel in little dusty Bethlehem is too good for him.
- 5.72** We're meant to be asking ourselves all the time: what's true power? What's true kingship? What does it look like when the Lord God joins to himself a human nature and comes to save us? That he doesn't come in the form of Caesar Augustus, but in this form? We're meant to see that.
- 5.73** And then this. "In that region, there were shepherds living in the fields, keeping watch over their flock by night. Then an angel of the Lord stood before them, and the glory of the Lord shone around them, and they were terrified." Shepherds. Again, we get romantic because of Christmas cards and the beautiful shepherds with their staffs out in the bucolic fields. Shepherds, in this time, were lowlifes. They were not taken seriously. They couldn't hold a proper job. They couldn't testify in court. A shepherd was like a lowlife.
- 5.74** Who gets the message, though? Who gets the message? Not one of Caesar's courtiers, not some high-ranking aristocrat, but these nobodies. And then, the angel. And I suggest to you, with the angel, we're coming, in some ways, to the heart of the message. So, the contrast is clear. An angel speaks.
- 5.75** Now, who's an angel? Again, get out of your mind all the imagery from Renaissance paintings of little bare-bottomed babies and all that because, in the Bible, Old Testament and New, what is invariably the reaction to an angel? Fear. Invariably, fear is the reaction to an angel because the angels always say, "Don't be afraid, don't be afraid," which implies they were afraid.
- 5.76** If some creature from a higher dimension of existence breaks into this world, some deeply unfamiliar reality breaks into this dimensional system from a higher dimensional system, of course, you're afraid. Of course, you're afraid. And the angel gives the message, and then it says, I love this, "And suddenly there was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host praising God, and saying, glory to God in the highest heaven, and on earth peace among those whom he favors."
- 5.77** A couple of things: one angel, terrifying. How about an army of them? Because that's the word in Greek. Here, it says "multitude." We say 'host' in some translations. The word is *stratias* in Greek. Our word 'strategy' comes from that or 'strategic.' *Stratia* is an army, an army. See what Luke is saying and how subversive it is? He begins with Caesar

Augustus, who could dominate the world because he had the biggest army in the world. But the baby king: no place to lay his head, wrapped in swaddling clothes, he's offered himself as food for the world—the baby king has got an army of angels on his side. And again, don't get sentimental about that. That means an army of supernaturally charged realities.

- 5.78** The message here is deeply subversive and challenging to the order of the world. You think you're running the show here, Cesar Augustus. You're not. And notice, too, in light of our lectures, "There was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly hosts praising God." What do the angels do all day? I made reference to the seraphim earlier, the burnt ones. They're burnt because they're so close to God. They're—remember, mouth to mouth, adoratio, they're praising God. The praise of God is always the key to everything, and the angelic host reveals that to us.
- 5.79** And then, listen to what they sing: "Glory to God in the highest." That's a formula. Not glory to money in the highest, pleasure in the highest, my country in the highest, my family in the highest—none of that. "Glory to God in the highest." And then, what's going to happen? "Then on earth peace among those whom he favors." This is a formula that if you give glory to God in the highest, peace will break out around you. In some ways, this is what I've been arguing the last several lectures. This is the basic biblical intuition.
- 5.80** What's going to happen now in the course of the Gospels? In a way, we're going to see the warfare between these two visions. Is it a walk in the park for Jesus? That he begins his preaching career, and everyone just loves him and says, "Oh, yeah, you're great." No, no. From the beginning, he's opposed, and you see why: because the world's organized according to Caesar Augustus and his army and his way of doing things.
- 5.81** That's why C.S. Lewis beautifully said, "How come God entered the world this way?" And the answer was, "Because he had to slip clandestinely behind enemy lines." Think of someone being parachuted in behind enemy lines. The enemy lines is the world. It's the way the world is organized. And so, the Son of God, the divinity and humanity meeting, has to parachute in quietly behind enemy lines.
- 5.82** But then, as his life and mission unfold, what happens? The forces of the Caesar Augustuses of the world are arrayed against him. It's in Matthew's account that we have Herod and the massacre of the innocents. Jesus is born. Beautiful Christmas message. It says, "Herod, and with him all Jerusalem, tremble with fear." That's a really telling image. Herod was worse than Caesar Augustus. He's one of the worst people in ancient history, but "with him all Jerusalem." It means the whole way of organizing the world trembles when this child comes.
- 5.83** And what does Herod try to do? Again, we're used to it because we've been doing the liturgical calendar for all these centuries. He tries to murder babies. He sends a

murderous army to kill those two years old and younger. There's so horrific about that, but that's the world reacting to the arrival of the Mashiach, of the Anointed One.

5.84 As Jesus emerges, forces, both visible and invisible, oppose him. Whether it's the scribes and Pharisees rising up against him or people trying to stone him. Even people in his home city lead him to the brow of the cliff to throw him over. And then, the invisible powers. "Jesus of Nazareth, what do you want of us? Have you come to destroy us? I know who you are," the demons speak. That means all the false ways of organizing things, both invisibly and visibly, come out aggressively to meet him, culminating—and I'm going to get to that, eventually—culminating in the supreme battle we call the cross.

5.85 But the Christmas story is not a little charming, sentimental tale we tell the kids. The Christmas story sets up this basic dynamic, which we'll look at now in the next lecture.

Lecture 6: God's Transformative Word

At a glance — God's transformative word.

- 6.1 Let's continue with our survey of the New Testament, looking at this figure of Jesus, the coming together of divinity and humanity in this non-competitive way. The closer God gets, the more beautiful and radiant creation becomes. We see it in this par excellence way in Jesus himself.
- 6.2 As I mentioned, though, last time, Jesus as a savior appears. He's the one that will heal broken humanity. But also Jesus as judge, because at every moment he's pointing out we're not where we ought to be. And the Christmas story has both, doesn't it? It has this glorious, beautiful dimension to it, and it's got a very dark side as well because what's anticipated is the struggle between two visions of life. It's going to culminate in the ultimate struggle of the cross.
- 6.3 But before I get there, I want to pause at the sermon on the Mount. Chapters 5, 6, and 7 of Matthew. The scholars have gone back and forth on this, but the most recent things I've read show that this represents probably the typical standard teaching of Jesus. So, as he would make his way around the villages and towns, he'd say, "I must go and preach." There probably was a moment when he actually delivered this thing in its totality, but it represents probably what he typically taught.
- 6.4 Read someone like Richard Baucom. It's a book called Jesus and the Eyewitnesses. He talks about the way in the ancient world things were remembered. And he thinks it's likely that even in Jesus' own lifetime on earth, people were already repeating his words and committing them to memory. So, we're probably pretty close to his voice as we listen to these words.
- 6.5 Here's how Matthew 5 begins: "When Jesus saw the crowds, he went up the mountain; and after he had sat down, his disciples came to him. Then he began to speak." So, several symbols that work there. The mountain, of course, is the typical biblical symbol. We go up; God comes down. It's Eden, it's Mount Zion, it's Jacob's ladder, it's the Temple Mount, it's all of that. It's also the mountain where Moses received the law, Mount Sinai. Now Jesus, the new Moses, is giving the law from the mountaintop.
- 6.6 The fact that he sits down is important. That was the attitude of a teacher in the ancient world. So, it was the opposite of what we do. The teacher here tends to stand as I am at the podium, and you're seated. It was the opposite in the ancient world, as the teacher would sit and people would arrange themselves at his feet. Or, in the case of Saint Augustine's preaching, they say that he would sit in his chair, the cathedra—that's why we call it a cathedral—and then, the people would stand. So, it's the opposite of what we do. So, Jesus here sitting down is in the attitude of the classical teacher.

- 6.7** What we get first now are the famous Beatitudes. Beatitudo in Latin means 'happy,' 'happiness,' 'joy,' and sometimes 'blessedness,' but the word in Greek that's used is makarios. 'Blessed are the poor in spirit.' 'Blessed are the meek.' Makarios. And Makarios has those senses of happy and blessed. But I've often exulted in the possibility that it might mean something like lucky, even. How lucky you are if you're a particular way. That's the blessings.
- 6.8** What I want to do—can we look at this with the priests of Baal in mind? Remember from the earlier lecture? The priests of Baal hopping around the altars, calling upon the gods. I mentioned Thomas Aquinas' idea of the four great substitutes for God: wealth, pleasure, power, and honor. Those are four things we typically seek in place of God. I imagine the priests of Baal hopping around those four altars. Keep that in mind, and I want to propose a way of looking at the Beatitudes.
- 6.9** So let's suppose we're all sinners here, so we all got one of these things, or more. Let's suppose wealth is your problem. Wealth is your poison. Wealth is the well that you go to over and over again. Wealth is your addiction. What does Jesus say? "How blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven." How about how lucky you are? How lucky you are if you are not addicted to wealth? The poor in spirit.
- 6.10** Is wealth bad in itself? No. Wealth is a creature like anything else. Wealth has a legitimate use within our economic system, etcetera. One can be wealthy without being addicted to wealth. One can be wealthy without worshiping wealth. What he's saying here is how lucky you are if you're not playing that game of addiction to wealth. As I mentioned the other day, that's exactly what will unfold in your life. You'll seek it, you'll get it, it'll give you a certain buzz, but it will wear off necessarily, and before you know it, you're addicted to wealth.
- 6.11** I remember this years ago when I was doing pastoral work, and this gentleman came to me after mass. He was maybe 45, very well dressed, well-coiffed, well-spoken, and he said to me, "Father, all my dreams have come true." That was his opening line to me. And I said, "Good for you." And he said, "And I'm miserable." That's a wonderful way to open a counseling session. All my dreams have come true, and I'm miserable.
- 6.12** Well, what were the dreams? His dreams were all the dreams of wealth: my first million by 30, my first 10 million by 40, et cetera. He laid out for me the whole plan, and he said, "The thing is, it all came true even more than I expected. I got all the things I wanted in terms of wealth. I have the house, the car, and everything, and I'm miserable." I remember, with him, I walked through the priest of Baal, about addiction, about the soul, and John of the Cross's infinite caverns and all of that. "How blessed you are if you're not addicted to wealth," says the Lord.
- 6.13** Let's say power is your hang-up. For a lot of people, that is deeply attractive, that wealth, power. How important is it for J.R.R. Tolkien? What's the fundamental problem? It's this ring of power. That's what everybody, deep down, wants in that

story. It's not pleasure. It's not wealth; it's not honor. It's a ring of power. Remember, there's a scene in the Lord of the Rings that I think is the scariest. It's not about Orcs and all that. To me, the scariest scene is when, at one point, Gandalf, the great wisdom figure—he's like a prophetic figure, a deeply good man—spies the ring. It's when Bilbo has it. He spies it, and you can tell in his eyes—it's in the movie version— in his eyes, that he wants it. He wants it. And if Gandalf, with all of his gifts, got the ring of power, it would have been a supreme disaster.

6.14 For a lot of people, that's the path they're on from the time they're little kids. "I want to get more and more power," and they'll sacrifice everything for it. They'll betray friends to get it. They'll subvert even people that are good to them to get it. Power. What's Jesus saying? "Blessed are the meek, for they will inherit the earth." How about how lucky you are, really, how lucky you are if you're not addicted to power? You're meek. I don't know any culture anywhere in the world that holds up meekness as a great value, but once we crack the code spiritually, we get it. You bet you're blessed if you're meek.

6.15 Let's say your hang-up is honor. And again, for some people, it's not wealth; it's not power, exactly. They want honor. They want titles. I think of—I go back to being a little kid, and I get good marks in grade school. I get an A or a 100. I loved that. I got a buzz from that. I remember showing it to my father. I go, "Look at that. I got this A, a 100," And my father would praise me. I loved that. I got addicted to it pretty early.

6.16 And so then, in time, it was like, "I need more than my father to honor me. I need my teachers in high school and my teachers in college, and I need people in the church." Honor is just as addictive as wealth and power. People, if they follow that path, seeking it like the priests of Baal, hopping around that altar, wounding themselves in their addiction, it's the same dynamic. The buzz wears off, and you need more of it. You need more of it. And you get people sometimes in their fifties and sixties who are like pathetic kids really waiting for praise. Praise me, honor me, tell me I'm good.

6.17 Notice, too, how when you're an honor addict, your life is utterly in the hands of other people. You're completely unfree because you need them. You're like a junkie, and they're your drug dealer. You need other people to keep feeding this addiction of yours. So, how about this? "Blessed are those"—how lucky you are—"blessed are those who are persecuted for righteousness sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. Blessed are you when people revile you and persecute you and utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my account. Rejoice and be gladden, for your reward is great in heaven."

6.18 What's going on there? It seems perverse. Why would you be blessed when people hate you? Because if you're an honor addict, how lucky you are if you can let go of that. You can let go of that. Here's the bottom line. Think of Jonah again. Think of any of the prophets. Sometimes, doing the will of God means what? That I'm not going to be wealthy. Wealth is not a bad thing. It's okay to be wealthy, but maybe, sometimes,

doing the will of God means I won't be wealthy. So, how lucky you are if you're not addicted to it; you're poor in spirit.

- 6.19** Sometimes, doing the will of God means that you're not going to have power. You're going to have to let go of power. Therefore, how lucky you are. Indeed, how lucky and fortunate you are if you're meek.
- 6.20** Sometimes, I would say most of the time, doing the will of God means you're not going to be honored. Look at the saints. Especially the martyrs are the supreme example, but almost all the saints. Doing the will of God means you're not going to get the honor of the world. The opposite. So, how lucky you are if people revile you and persecute you, utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my account? "Rejoice and be glad, for your reward is great in heaven."
- 6.21** What does that mean? That means you've transposed your life to a higher key. Don't think simply in terms of this life and then the next life in heaven. It does mean that, but even now, even now, your reward is great in heaven because you've transposed your life from this ordinary key where wealth, pleasure, power, and honor run the show to a higher key. Can you see why—it's true again and again in the lives of saints—why the saints are so annoying to people? They are up and down because the saints are a constant challenge to this way of organizing our lives.
- 6.22** So, where did I skip? I got wealth—pleasure. So, let's say pleasure is your poison. And that's true. Go back to the ancient world. There were the hedonistic philosophers that said that's what it's all about. It's pleasure. Pleasure could take refined forms or unrefined forms, but finally, that's what we all want: to find pleasure. Whether the pleasure of reading a book, or pleasure of sex, or pleasure of food and drink, that's what we all want.
- 6.23** What does Jesus say? "How blessed are you who mourn." It seems perverse again, doesn't it? How lucky I am if I'm mourning. How about how lucky you are if you're not addicted to pleasure? You're not addicted to pleasure. Pleasure is good, but it's not God, and if you make it God, you'll be hopping around the altar of pleasure before you know it. Talk to anyone addicted to food, to sex, to drink, or to drugs. It's the same thing. They got addicted to pleasure early on. They got a buzz from it. Yes, indeed.
- 6.24** Look at the different types of sexual addiction in our culture today. It's all over this question of pleasure. How lucky you are if you mourn; if you're not addicted to pleasure because sometimes doing God's will means you'll have anything but pleasure. This is not some masochism or some otherworldly puritanism. It's not that at all. The glory of God is a human being fully alive. "Eat of all the trees." God's not trying to deny us pleasure, but he is trying to deny us turning pleasure into God. Therefore, how lucky you are, blessed you are, if you mourn.

- 6.25** I find in my pastoral work, of the big four, this may be the biggest. It's the one that is the most—grabbed people by the soul and wreaked havoc in their lives, turning pleasure into your God. No, no. That God has got to be dethroned.
- 6.26** All right, those are, if you want, the negative Beatitudes. It's the Beatitudes, things, that we should avoid. If we are free of those addictions, then what? Listen now, if you want to, the positive Beatitudes. "Blessed are the merciful, for they will receive mercy." This is spiritual physics, everybody. If I'm free of those addictions, I can become aligned unto God. Adoratio. I'm mouth to mouth with God.
- 6.27** Who is God? "God is love" is the New Testament language. The Old Testament has that beautiful Hebrew term *chesed*, which means 'tender mercy.' That's what God is. That's all God is. *Chesed*, tender mercy. So, if I'm addicted to God— that's okay—I'm attached to God, I'm honoring and worshiping God, then necessarily, mercy will flow through me into the world. There's the formula.
- 6.28** Don't buy Oprah books. If you want the formula to be happy, that's it. Adore the Lord, and then allow the mercy that God is to flow through you into the world. That's the happy life. I bet my life on it. I pledge my life to this teaching of Jesus. I found after all these years, it's truer and truer to me. So, free of wealth, pleasure, power, honor, and addictions, I am free now to be a vehicle and conduit of God's mercy.
- 6.29** I like this from Joseph Campbell. Do you remember him from years ago? The comparative mythologist. Campbell said, as he surveyed all the religions of the world, he felt they all had this in common. That something like compassion or fellow feeling is fundamental, and I think that's right. I'm not claiming that all religions are the same. They're not, and there are great differences. But I think that it is true that all the religions come together in talking about mercy as a fundamental good. It happens when we get free.
- 6.30** If I'm free of addictions, I can be pure of heart. So, Jesus says, "How blessed are the single-hearted" or "the pure of heart." What does that mean? The heart, for the ancient Hebrews, was the seat of consciousness and everything else. We tend to think of the head; they thought of the heart. But think of it as the center of who you are. If you're single-hearted, that means there's no ambiguity in your life about what is most basic, about whom you adore. That's what it means.
- 6.31** Again, I mentioned Kierkegaard the other day. The saint is someone whose life is about one thing. That's what it means. The saint is someone who's pure of heart. And this is a really good point to examine your conscience on. So, if someone asks me, "What's your life all about?" I'll say, "God," and I'll really mean that.
- 6.32** But then, as we begin lent today, ask that question. "Really? Am I really pure of heart? Is my heart really undivided?" Good question. But if I'm free of addictions, then I'm free for this purity of heart. And then I love, "How blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness." This, again, is a really good point to examine your conscience on.

- 6.33** When you wake up in the morning, you get out of bed, and you say, "What am I seeking today?" Really ask and answer that question honestly. "What am I trying to get today?" And you can say, "I'm trying to be successful at my work. I'm trying to have a pleasant day. I'm trying to make some money. I'm trying to have—" Whatever.
- 6.34** The saint is someone who says when he or she wakes up in the morning, "What I'm seeking is righteousness." Meaning, I'm seeking to do the right thing. I'm seeking to do the will of God. If you can wake up in the morning and really mean that, really mean it, "That's what I want," even if doing the right thing means I'm not going to make the money I might have made. It means I might lose a friendship I didn't really want to lose. What do you want? What do you want?
- 6.35** This is true over the centuries to the present day. When a young kid comes to a Benedictine monastery and seeks entry, the question he's asked is, "What do you want? What are you looking for?" That's a good question because if the answer is, "I'm looking for an easy life, I'm looking so my parents will respect me, I'm looking to escape from society, I'm looking for—" Those are all bad answers. There's only one answer. There's only one answer that will ever be acceptable: "I'm seeking God." The young man has to say, "I'm seeking God."
- 6.36** There's a story in the Benedictine tradition about a young kid that comes to the monastery, and an older monk takes him away out into the woods, and there's a little pond. The kid thinks, "Is he doing some baptismal thing?" He puts the kid's head under the water, and he holds it and holds it, and the kid begins to struggle. He keeps holding it, and he keeps holding it. Now, he's flailing around, but he's holding it and holding it. And finally, at the last minute, he pulls his head up, and the kid gasps for air. And the old monk says, "When you want God as much as you want that air, come back to the monastery."
- 6.37** "How blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness." I want to be a righteous person. It's not self-evident, fellow sinners. It's not self-evident. We can say that, but to live it is another thing.
- 6.38** And then, beautifully, I'll say more about it in a few minutes. "Blessed are the peacemakers, for they will be called children of God." Just as when you are aligned to God, you become a conduit of mercy into the world. You become, ipso facto, whether you really want to or not—when you are aligned to God, you become a peacemaker.
- 6.39** My experience of the saints that I have known—I've known a few in my life, real saintly people—peace is what they exude. It's the integrity of their own life; the way their own life hangs together exudes peace. It produces peace around them.
- 6.40** Have you known people who are just war makers? Wherever they go, trouble ensues, quarrels break out, and people get unhappier. I see it all the time. I see it in myself. It's part of what it means to be a sinner. "How blessed are the peacemakers." So, what you have here, at the very beginning, is a formula. It's for people that adore the Lord.

They'll start looking like this. Free of addictions and, therefore, free to be a conduit of grace.

- 6.41** A couple of things now: more about the sermon on the mount. "You, my followers," says Jesus, "are the salt of the earth. But if salt has lost its taste, how can its saltiness be restored?" I wonder how many people in our society today think of religion as a privatized matter of how I find peace and how I find a sense of purpose in it.
- 6.42** But that is not biblical at all. That's not biblical at all. You're the salt of the earth. In other words, I've got a task for you. You're supposed to accomplish something in the world. What does salt do? Salt, in the ancient world, was a preservative. So, before refrigeration, they would salt meat to preserve it. So, salt is meant to preserve what's good and make it tasty and savory.
- 6.43** Do we think of our lives that way in the world? That part of what it means to be a Christian, to be filled with the spirit of Christ, is to preserve what's worth preserving in the world and to make what's good even spicier and better. Yeah, people who live the Beatitudes will do that; It'll be like breathing.
- 6.44** But now, do the flip side. You're the salt of the earth. When the Romans would conquer a city, they'd kill the people in it. They'd knock down the walls, and then they would salt the earth to make sure that nothing would ever grow there. Salt the earth. You're the salt of the earth. Is that a positive thing? The salt of the earth meant that nothing could grow there.
- 6.45** Are we meant to get in the way of bad things in the world? Yes. "Oh, that's none of my business. I'm just leading my spiritual life on my own terms." No, no. You're meant to enhance what's beautiful. You're meant to get in the way. You're meant to obviate what's wicked in the world. That's a tough assignment. Think of Jonah. "Hey, Jonah. Go to Nineveh, the big city, the capital city of the enemy empire, and tell them how bad they are." Well, that's part of our task, too.
- 6.46** "You're the light of the world. A city built on a hill cannot be hid." You're the light of the world. The world is meant to see things more clearly by the light of Christians living their lives. People that live the Beatitudes become a source of illumination for the rest so they can guide their lives by the light provided by the followers of Jesus.
- 6.47** And then, I've been saying this in the last couple of days, "Do you think I've come to abolish the law or the prophets? I've come not to abolish but to fulfill." Right. Right. With the coming of Jesus, temple, covenant, prophecy, all of that has been fulfilled, not abrogated. In the Beatitudes, what you see is what the law was meant to produce. So, yes, I should be understood in light of the Old Testament, the Lord is saying.
- 6.48** With that, I want to get to what I think is the rhetorical heart of the sermon on the mount, and it has to do with this vexing problem of the love of our enemies. These texts, I've been hearing them since I was a kid. I've been preaching them since I was 26

years old. They always confound me. They always break my heart. They always crack my mind open. They always cause trouble for me. They always bother me. Well, they're meant to, of course. They're meant to, of course.

- 6.49** God is love. God is hesed. God is tender mercy. What's love? Love is to will the good of the other as other. Remember? So, not loving myself through you: I'm righteous so that you might be righteous back to me. That isn't love. To love is to will the good of the other as other. Therefore, what is the greatest test of love? It has to be the love of our enemies because if I love my friend, who's very likely to love me in return, I'm kind to someone who's likely to be kind back to me, what does that prove?
- 6.50** Doesn't Jesus say exactly that in the sermon? If you loan money to someone who's going to pay it back to you, the pagans do as much. If you give a party for those who will then return the favor to you, what credit is that to you? But when you love your enemy, I will the good of the one who will not will the good back to me. Now, I've proven my love, and I'm like somebody. Who? I'm like the one who "makes his sun to shine on the good and the bad alike." That's from the sermon on the mount. "Who makes his rain to fall on the just and the unjust alike."
- 6.51** "Be ye perfect as your heavenly father is perfect." I'm not just trying to be ethically upright or be in line with Socrates, Immanuel Kant, or any moral teacher. No, no, I'm trying to be perfect as my heavenly father is perfect because if I'm adoring the Lord, then his manner of being is going to flow through me. And the greatest test is enemy love because that's how God loves. God loves those who love him. Uh-huh. He loves those who hate him. Uh-huh. He loves those who are indifferent to him. Uh-huh. That's all he knows how to do. That's all he's got in his bag.
- 6.52** When you say God is love, it's an extraordinary thing to say because every religion will say something like "God loves" or "God has love." But for the Christian faith, when we say "God is love," he can't help himself. That's all he is. That's his inmost nature to love and to will the good of the other.
- 6.53** How strange, everyone—think about this for a minute. Think about this. I can love my enemies in the measure that God's way of being has somehow invaded me. We speak of the theological virtues of faith, hope, and love. Do you know what that means? The cardinal virtues, like justice, temperance, and all that—Aristotle knew that a long time ago that they can be practiced. I can perfect those. I can try to do courageous and just things. But then, there's the theological virtues: faith, hope, and love. I can't practice my way to those. Those are gifts that come from adoration. They come from alignment unto God.
- 6.54** Paul says, "The three things that last: faith, hope, and love. And the greatest of these is love." Do you know why? Because in heaven, faith will fade away. I won't need faith in heaven. Hope will fade away because I will have realized what I was always hoping for. But what won't fade away? Love because love is what heaven is. Love is the life of God.

So, the enemy love is so important because it's the test of love. It's the way we know we are living in alignment with God. That's why it's so difficult and so wonderful and powerful.

- 6.55** Now, with that more general principle, let's look at maybe the most difficult text in the sermon. It's verse 38, Chapter 5. "You've heard that it was said, 'An eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth.' But I say to you, do not resist an evildoer. If anyone strikes you on the right cheek, turn the other also. If anyone wants to sue you and take your coat, give them your cloak as well. If anyone forces you to go one mile, go a second mile."
- 6.56** Again, I've read these texts for years. They still bother me. As I read them now, they bother me. "Eye for an eye, tooth for tooth." That's a good principle, by the way, from the Old Testament. It was meant to limit violence. That's not an excuse for violence; it's a limitation. "Hey, someone hurt me; I'm gonna kill that guy." Well, no, no. This law says, "No, no, restrain your vengeance." So, an eye for an eye, a tooth for a tooth.
- 6.57** Now, go beyond that. If someone knocks your tooth out, you can knock his tooth out. Don't take his eye out, too. That's the point. That's a good principle. So, Jesus starts with that. "You've heard it said, 'An eye for an eye, tooth for tooth.' But I say to you, do not resist an evildoer. If anyone strikes you on the right cheek, turn the other also." What isn't this? This is not passivity in the face of evil. It's not surrendering to evil. It's not caving in. All of this is under the rubric of love. Love is not a sentiment. It's willing the good of the other. Therefore, what's he describing?
- 6.58** In Jesus' time, you would never have used your left hand for any social intercourse. It was thought to be unclean. So, if someone strikes you on the right cheek, what does that mean? That means they hit you like this, boom, with the back of the hand. That was a gesture of contempt. If you were disciplining a slave or someone you thought was inferior, you'd strike them like that. If someone strikes you on the right cheek, what should you do? Fight back? No. Run away? No. Turn the other cheek.
- 6.59** Stand your ground and turn the other cheek. Which is a way of doing what? Saying, "I refuse to cooperate with the world that you're living in. I'm not going to allow you to treat me that way again, and I'm going to mirror back to you the violence you've done to me." You see, please, an act of love. Love means willing the good of the other. I fight back. Well, that doesn't express love. I run away. I haven't benefited that guy at all. But I stand my ground, and I turn the other cheek. What am I doing? I'm trying to bring that person into a new spiritual space.
- 6.60** This is very interesting. The other example here. "If anyone wants to sue you and take your coat, give them your cloak as well." This is someone who would be very poor, and they couldn't pay their debts back, so they're being sued for the coat off their back. It's an act of legal aggression, if you want. This is physical aggression. This is legal aggression. Suing a poor person for the coat off his back. So, what's Jesus saying here?

If someone does that to you, fight back? No. Run away? No. Give him your undergarment, too.

- 6.61** "You got the gall to sue me for the coat off my back? Hey, take my undergarment, too." What are you doing, in a provocative way, a humorous way, even, is you're shaming the person into seeing what he's doing. You're shaming that person into finally coming to terms with the legal violence he's perpetrating.
- 6.62** Now, who knew this principle? I mentioned him yesterday: Martin Luther King, of course, who, as a young kid, would have read these texts and would have preached them. He also was deeply inspired by Mohandas Gandhi. And you know the story of young Mohandas Gandhi coming to London in 1880—I guess it would have been—as a law student. He was first so shy he wouldn't even leave his apartment. But, finally, he fell in with a group of Christians, and they urged him to read the Bible, which he had never read.
- 6.63** He got lost in the Old Testament, which people often do, but he started reading the New Testament. See, Matthew is right in the beginning of the New Testament, and Gandhi read these texts. Young Mohandas Gandhi, a Hindu, learning the Bible—they took his breath away. He said that this is the key to transforming all of society. And his Christian friends said to him, "Well, you know, we don't take it all that seriously." Gandhi did. Gandhi did. He understood that. He practiced his nonviolence in India and indeed wrought an extraordinary social change.
- 6.64** Well, the young Martin Luther King, reading directly, of course, as a Christian, but also finding inspiration from Gandhi, who, in turn, found it here. King launched his social revolution, which was a stance of nonviolence. But watch what he did, he and his followers. It wasn't fighting back, but by God, it wasn't running away, was it? It was a provocative mirroring back to a racist society its own racism.
- 6.65** Here's an example I love, not from King, but from Bishop Tutu. Remember, from South Africa? He was a civil rights leader. They say that when he was a very young man in Johannesburg, the capital city. He was going along this raised wooden sidewalk over a muddy street. He came face to face with a white man who was a racist, and he said to Tutu, "Get off the sidewalk. I don't make way for gorillas." So, Tutu got off the sidewalk. He gestured broadly and said, "I do." That's a very good example of turning the other cheek. It's not fighting back, but by God, it wasn't running away. It was mirroring back to the violent person something of his own violence. It was standing his ground and saying, "No, no, I won't cooperate with the world that you're in."
- 6.66** Do you see why these people—I mentioned John Paul the other day in Poland, a very similar thing. John Paul, with no military support whatsoever but simply talking about God, simply talking about God brought down the Soviet Union. This is a way, everybody. It's a path that Jesus opens up, and it's people who are living in adoratio,

living in right praise, who are allowing the divine mercy to flow through them, and who aren't addicted to wealth, pleasure, power, and honor.

- 6.67** What if these great heroes of nonviolence were addicted to those things? They would never have accomplished it. They would never have accomplished it. But free from that, then the divine mercy can flow through them into the world. I think that's what we're talking about here.
- 6.68** It's still dynamite. Peter Moran, who is the co-founder of the catholic worker movement, a marvelous figure, had this wonderful line. He said, "We've taken the dynamite of the church, we placed it in hermetically sealed containers, and we've sat on the lid." He said, "The point is to blow up the dynamite of the church." Dunamis means 'power.' It's one of Paul's favorite words. Dunamis. Dynamite. Dynamite. Power. There's power in these words. Power. Don't tell me that's naive idealism. No. Gandhi, King, John Paul II, and lots of other examples are people that really did affect massive social change by unleashing the power of this.
- 6.69** I hope it's clear that the guy who delivered this sermon is going to annoy a lot of people. He'll lift up people and inspire them very deeply, and he'll annoy a lot of people because practically everything in this sermon runs counter to the way the sinful world is organized. That he's opposed by forces visible and invisible should not surprise us. The Gospels can be read as this steady march toward Jerusalem. Jerusalem means one thing in the Gospels: it means the cross.
- 6.70** Jesus set his face toward Jerusalem. After he heals Bartimaeus, the blind man, he says that he's heading toward Jerusalem, and Bartimaeus, having recovered his sight, follows him up the road. Jerusalem means coming fully to terms with all the implications of the way he lived and the way he taught.
- 6.71** How can we approach the cross? Think of it as the downward trajectory of the incarnation. We say that the word became flesh. The word of God becomes one of us. He joins to himself a human nature. Is that a kind of journey downward? Sure, but then he went further— Jesus reaching out to humanity and all of its suffering, Jesus healing the sick, and so on, preaching to the poor. But then, he goes all the way down into all forms of human dysfunction and finally into that place that scares us the most and, in fact, gives rise to all the other dysfunction. What am I talking about? Death.
- 6.72** Look, we can run from it, we can deny it, we can drug ourselves because of it, but death is a great fact of life in this world. It hovers over everything. Why did we become so difficult and so self-absorbed and so prideful and so violent and so resentful? Because deep, deep down, we're afraid of death. Death haunts us. So, where does the Son of God go? "He emptied himself and took the form of a slave," Saint Paul said. "Being born in the likeness of men, he was known to be of human estate. And it was thus that he humbled himself, obediently accepting even death"—let's go further even—"death on a cross."

- 6.73** The cross. I'm wearing a cross. If someone came in a time machine from the ancient world and they were in this room and they said, "The guy up there in black, he's a religious leader, a religious speaker," the ancient person would say, "What the heck? Why is he wearing that?" This would be like wearing an electric chair or wearing a noose. This was what frightened people the most, you could say, in Jesus' time, was the Roman cross.
- 6.74** They got it from the Persians, they think, this awful means of execution, the crucifixion, but the Romans perfected it, certainly. The person was affixed to this upright beam, and they put the cross beam on it. The person was affixed either by ropes or by nails, sometimes by both. Usually stripped naked. That was part of the torture, part of the humiliation of the cross. It was put up in a public place so people could see the crucified person and be put off by it.
- 6.75** The torture was a combination of bleeding to death and asphyxiation. As you were struggling to breathe, you had to lift yourself up on your crucified feet, which caused, literally, excruciating pain. That's what the word means. Excrucia. So, the worst kind of pain, excruciating pain, meant the pain of the cross. And this would go on—it's hard even to imagine—sometimes, for an entire day or several days. And the person, of course, was not fed, not given anything to drink, and was allowed simply to die in this horrible condition and then, typically, left on the cross for the body to rot away. It was horrific, meant to be horrific. It was a state-sponsored terrorism. That's what the cross was.
- 6.76** So, when Paul says that Jesus became one of us "and obediently accepting even death." That the Son of God would die in his bed of natural causes, that would be remarkable enough, but then you can almost hear Paul lowering his voice and he says, "Death on a cross." They couldn't imagine anything worse than that.
- 6.77** They say that Cicero, who was the greatest rhetorician of the classical period, could articulate any thought he wanted. He wrote a letter to a friend of his trying to describe someone who had been crucified, and he used an elaborate circumlocution because he didn't want to talk about it directly. It wasn't depicted for the first several centuries of Christian life. I think it's because people were too close to it. They knew it. They had a memory of what crucifixion meant.
- 6.78** "He accepted even death, death on a cross." Think now of Jesus on the cross in that excruciating state, having been a victim of deep institutional injustice, standing before Pontius Pilate, the representative of Rome, the great political power of the time, who blithely says to Jesus, "Truth. What's that?" When the Lord says, "I've come to testify to the truth," Pilate, summing up all of political corruption across the century, says, "Truth. What's that?" I don't care about truth. I'm a man of power. That's what he's saying. I'm a man of power and honor, maybe. I got no interest in truth, pal.

- 6.79** Jesus was brutalized by his own people. The Sanhedrin, his treatment there. Betrayed by one of his own. I think as we go through life—I find this in my own life and the lives of others I talk to—that's one of the very worst things to experience, isn't it? It's when not an enemy or someone you're indifferent to betrays you, but when a friend betrays you. The betrayal of Judas. The denial of Peter—"not only my friend; he's the leader. He's the leader of my group. He's the one I'm going to build my church on."
- 6.80** Peter. He three times says, "I don't know the guy." Think of the scapegoating mob that formed. Remember when Peter's there in the courtyard of the high priest's house, and they say, "You're with him. You were with him." "No, no, no. I don't know anything about him." "Come on. Your accent gives you away. You're a Galilean. You were with that Jesus." "No, no, no, I wasn't." Why is he so afraid? Because he feels the scapegoating mob is forming. That's a very dangerous thing.
- 6.81** Think of the sheer cruelty of the way Jesus is treated. Think of the shattered quality of his life at that point. And then, let's press it all the way. On the cross, Jesus, dying, says, "God, my God, why have you abandoned me?"
- 6.82** G.K. Chesterton, the great catholic writer, said, "On the cross, it's as though God became an atheist." I see what he's driving at there. Jesus went all the way down. The father sent the son all the way down. Yes, into our human condition, but he didn't live as some prince. No, no, he went into all of it, into despair, into hopelessness, into fear, into cruelty, into treason, into violence, into the sheer torture of the cross. All of it. All of it. He went all the way down.
- 6.83** Now, why? So that he might bring the divine mercy into all of those expressions of our humanity. How does he save us? How does Jesus save us? How does he save us? He's got to go down all the way. Someone who's fixing a car has got to get his hands dirty. You can't fix a car from a distance. If you're trying to deal with a friend who's in pain, you can't do it from a thousand miles away. You got to get into that person's life.
- 6.84** So, God in Christ comes all the way down into our dysfunction so as to bring there the divine mercy, "accepting even death, death on a cross," the death of the son of God. God knows what it's like to be dead. He goes into death itself, into what frightens us the most.
- 6.85** Why am I here 2000 years later, still talking about this Jesus if he just stayed in his grave? If he just stayed in his grave, you'd say that he was a well-meaning, idealistic preacher. His teaching is still interesting to listen to, but he would have been long forgotten. He would have passed into irrelevancy a long time ago.
- 6.86** But what is the still startling claim? Let me put it this way. The first Christians burst out of Jerusalem with the message that this Jesus is the Messiah. He's the Mashiach, the new David. Wait a minute, wait a minute. The clearest indication possible that someone was not the Messiah would have been his death at the hands of Israel's enemies. The Messiah was supposed to carry the day, deal with the enemies of the

nation, and establish himself as King and Lord. Therefore, the clearest possible indication that he's not the Messiah would be the crucifixion.

- 6.87** So, what gives? How do you explain that the first Christians are acknowledging the cross? They don't hide it at all. No, no. Paul says, "I preach one thing: Christ and him crucified." I'm not hiding it, but at the same time, I'm saying that this Jesus, whom you crucified, is the Mashiach of Israel. The only way to explain it, I'm speaking as a Christian, but also, I would say, even as a Nestorian—historian, not Nestorian—as a historian, is the resurrection of Jesus from the dead.
- 6.88** A nice myth, a legend, a symbol? Try again. My generation, when I was going through school, we heard a lot of that, the attempts to explain the resurrection away. It's a literary device. It's one more myth of the dying and rising God and all that. If you're telling a myth, you begin with things like "once upon a time" because myths aren't about historical events. They're about great truths regarding nature or society or something. No one asked who was the king of—who was the emperor of Rome when Hercules was around. No, because Hercules is a mythological figure.
- 6.89** Then, there's Jesus. Listen to the language they use when they talk about the resurrection: "We who ate and drank with him after his resurrection from the dead." Peter says that very blithely in the Acts of the Apostles. It always takes my breath away that line: "We who ate and drank with him after his resurrection from the dead." Here's Peter, the Galilean fisherman, who knew this Jesus from Nazareth and saw him die. And we know where he's buried, too, by the way: the most beautiful grave marker in the world is called Saint Peter's Basilica in Rome. That Galilean fisherman is underneath that building to this day, and he says, "We who ate and drank with him after his resurrection from the dead."
- 6.90** I don't think it's possible to explain the emergence of Christianity as a messianic movement apart from this fact of the resurrection. Can I read you—and I'll bring it to a close with this—the beginning of Mark's Gospel, which the scholars tell us is the first Gospel written, maybe around the year 70, maybe earlier, they're saying now. Listen to this. "The beginning of the good news of Jesus Christ, the Son of God."
- 6.91** If someone out of a Jewish tradition says "the beginning" he's hearkening back to the very first words of the Old Testament: "In the beginning, when God created the heavens and the earth." Saint John says, "In the beginning was the word." And here it is, "The beginning of the good news." Beginning, a new creation as a new world has emerged. That's the point here. I'm going to tell you the story about a new world emerging. The beginning of the good news. In Greek, there is euaggelion. And our words evangelization and evangelistic come from that. Gospel, God spell, good news.
- 6.92** When a Roman emperor won a battle, he would send evangelists ahead of him with the good news that he won this victory. That's where euaggelion was used. "Hey, I got good news. Caesar won. Caesar won a battle. Good news, everybody." Here's Saint Mark—

who knows exactly where he wrote the Gospel, some say in Rome itself. His friend Peter had just been put to death around the year 64, 65, and in the belly of the beast, he says, "I got the real euaggelion, and it's got nothing to do with Caesar or any of his minions or any imperial victory. I got the real good news. It has to do with the victory of Jesus Christ, whom you killed and God raised."

- 6.93** Right away, it's a deeply provocative line. It remains that way to this day. "The good news of Jesus Christ," *Iēsous Chrīstós* in Greek. *Iēsous Chrīstós* is just the Greekifying of Yeshua Mashiach. Yeshua Mashiach. Jesus, the Anointed One. David. David's come. David's come. The One we've been waiting for. The long-awaited David's come.
- 6.94** And then, I love this. He calls him the Son of God. Now, we say, "Yeah, sure, he's the Son of God. But see, go back to the first century. In Greek, there is *Yíos tou theoú*, the son of the God. *Yíos tou theoú*. That was Caesar's title.
- 6.95** Because, remember, when Julius Caesar is assassinated, and then he's made into a god, they call him *Divus Caesar*. He's the divine Caesar. Then, he adopts his nephew—he adopted him—Augustus, Octavian. And so, Octavian becomes the *huios theoú*. He becomes the son of the God, the son of Caesar. And from that point on, it became an imperial title .
- 6.96** Again, here's Saint Mark in the belly of the beast saying, "I got the real good news." It has nothing to do with Caesar. It has to do with God's victory over sin and death. God's establishment of a new world. And if you want to know who the *huios theoú* is, the son of God, it's not Caesar. It's this Yeshua Mashiach.
- 6.97** I'll close with this. Can you see why so many of the first Christians ended up in prison and put to death? Because they knew exactly what they were saying. We read this language, and we spiritualize it right away. They knew exactly the revolutionary intent of this language, the dynamite quality of this language.
- 6.98** That's the church's task to the present day. You're salt. You're light. The idea is to create, through God's grace, a new world that's born of *adoratio*, that's born of the burning bush, God's presence making us luminous and beautiful.
- 6.99** God bless you all. Thanks. Thank you.